



BESTSELLING AUTHOR
KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

The New Wife on
MILFORD COURT
BOOK ONE

the new wife on milford court

Book One

kirsten mccurran



© 2025 Aphrodite Omnimedia. All Rights Reserved. No part of this work may be reproduced for distribution by any means physical, mechanical, or digital without the explicit written permission of the author.

This is a work of fiction. All characters and locations are fictitious or used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons or places is entirely coincidental.

Cover Image © gpointstudio. Licensed from Depositphotos.

First digital edition published February 2025

First paperback edition published February 2025

Chapter 1
Chapter 2
Chapter 3
Chapter 4
Chapter 5
Chapter 6
Chapter 7
Chapter 8
Chapter 9
Chapter 10
Chapter 11
Chapter 12
Chapter 13

The New Wife on Milford Court: Book Two Good Wives, Bad Behavior
Sam Surrenders to the Neighbors
Sasha's Vacation Surrender
Sexy Tumbles
Hannah Surrenders to the Landlords

About the Author

one

Jeremy never thought the day would arrive. They were really moving into their new, fancy, big house. Some might derisively call it excessive, but to Jeremy, it represented years of toil and stress and sacrifice. He was confident that he'd *earned* this. If only April was as thrilled as him.

April just needed time to adjust, he hoped. Although not as bold as her husband, Jeremy knew she'd grow to love their new home just as much as he did. He looked up at the Spanish Colonial Revival home and still didn't quite believe it was theirs. He never dreamed he'd be able to give his family a home like that.

April loved her routine as much as she hated change. Maybe more. *She'll find a new routine*, he thought. *She'll find new friends and an even better life than we had back in New Jersey.*

Moving so far away was April's main concern when Jeremy told her about his big promotion. She acted like Hamilton, New Jersey, and South Florida were on different planets. He reminded his wife more than once that the towns were only a couple-hour flight apart. The grandparents could come to visit the kids anytime they wanted. And their friends would be thrilled to have a place to stay in sunny Florida. The new house had more than enough room for guests, even with their two kids. There were five bedrooms!

"Isn't this great?" he said, trying to draw April into his enthusiasm. She'd just come out of the house with Gabi and Gabe. Their kids were wide-eyed at their opulent new surroundings. They were on board the moment they were they'd have a pool.

“Are we gated community people, Jeremy? Is there a real sense of community here?” “*Community* is right in there, isn’t it, honey? The materials said they have events at the clubhouse all the time. We’ll get to know everyone.”

April looked around the cul-de-sac skeptically. There were four other houses tightly grouped together on Milford Court. The big houses were on tiny plots of land. Her first complaint when they’d come down to tour the house last month was that they were giving up their yard.

The front yard here was practically non-existent, just a small crescent of perfectly landscaped green with a tall palm tree between stretches of concrete: the driveway, walkways, and the sidewalk. The back of the property was all pool and patio. Jeremy would miss the homey feel of their old neighborhood, too, but felt like they were gaining much more than they’d given up.

“And we already know one family here. Mr. Siegel and his wife live right over there,” he said, gesturing to a house in the middle of the cul-de-sac. The houses were not cookie-cutter, even though it was a planned community. The house belonging to his new boss was larger and fancier than the others.

“We don’t know them, Jeremy. I met him twice. You’ve met him, what, two or three times?”

“Four, but who’s counting? Watch out, honey.”

Jeremy took April by the waist and swept her aside before the busy movers ran her over. They were unloading a truck full of the Sampsons’ belongings, not that they’d brought many. He knew right away the comfy furniture from their traditional suburban home back in Jersey would not fit with their new luxury home. He hoped April would be excited about decorating a new house, but she just complained about how much everything cost. He assured her they could afford it with his new salary.

“I know Mr. Siegel. He’s a great guy.”

April finally smiled and poked him in the ribs. “Yeah, you’re besties. That’s why you keep calling him *Mr. Siegel*. I’m sure we’ll be invited over for a barbeque this weekend.”

“He’s the one who found this house for us.”

“That doesn’t mean he plans to hang out with you. Do you even know if they have kids? He’s so much older than us. His kids must be grown.

Unless he found a young trophy wife and had to start over again.”

“Very funny. You’d better be nice if we do get invited over. I don’t think he’s the trophy wife type, anyway. He’s a good family man.”

“Oh, babe, he’s definitely the trophy wife type.” April stretched up and kissed his cheek. “Sorry, babe. I don’t mean to be a wet blanket. I want to be just as excited as you. I am. I swear. It’s just a lot. We’ve completely uprooted our lives for your new job, and I’m going to need a minute to get used to it.”

“I know. And I know it’s a lot. You’re a trooper for handling it so well.”

Jeremy understood her reservations—about everything—if he was honest. He

projected much more confidence than he actually felt. He didn’t know Tommy Siegel all that well. They had met just four times.

Their first meeting was at a client mixer in New York thrown by Jeremy’s former firm. Tommy Siegel was a senior VP at Stirling Sports Management, one of the firm’s major clients. Jeremy had done some work on the account, but there was no reason Tommy Siegel should have any idea who he was. But the man went out of his way to find Jeremy and compliment his work.

April said he gave her an uneasy vibe that night. He was just as interested in getting to know her as he was Jeremy, but he just didn’t see it. Tommy Siegel was just a slick, player type, which was not her type at all. The man probably poured on the charm for every attractive woman he met. It didn’t mean anything. And Jeremy knew his wife was very attractive.

Mr. Siegel asked Jeremy to lunch the next time he was in town. The pretext was to go over contract provisions for a rookie Stirling had just signed before the draft, but there was no reason to seek him out for that kind of work. Jeremy didn’t say no. He was on the partner track, and this could only help.

Their third meeting was a dinner where Mr. Siegel pitched him the in-house counsel job for Stirling Sports Management, and he insisted April be present. He sent a car to take them from their house in Hamilton all the way up to New York City. Mrs. Siegel wasn’t there, but apparently, there was one. She worked in local news back home in South Florida. Tommy Siegel turned on the charm like he was trying to seduce both of the Sampsons.

April thought the job was too good to be true. Jeremy agreed, but the money was outrageous. He didn't see how he could turn it down. She didn't see how he could take the job. Stirling Sports Management was based in Miami, and they would have to move if he took it. April loved their life. They had a great circle of friends, and her job at a non-profit was what she'd always wanted to do. But the money Mr. Siegel offered was seriously insane. It was life-changing money. Even she had to admit it. Jeremy had her when he pointed out the kind of life they could give the kids.

Jeremy didn't remember too much of his fourth evening with Tommy Siegel, and he did not share the things they did with his wife. April was pointedly not invited that night. Mr. Siegel took him out on the town to celebrate the signing. He said it was the way he celebrated with new athletes he signed. Jeremy was sure he behaved himself, but April would not have approved of their surroundings. His wife wasn't a prude, but nor was she the type who'd approve of her husband hitting all the high-end strip clubs in Manhattan.

"When can we go in the pool?" Gabe needled, pulling on Jeremy's shorts. Six-year-olds were not known for their patience.

"We'll get there. I promise, buddy. But there's a lot to do before we can relax. Why don't you and your sister go check out your new rooms again? Your new bed is pretty cool."

"It's so cool. It looks just like an army tent!"

Gabe dragged his older sister back into the house, leaving Jeremy and his wife outside to watch the movers pull the last of their stuff out of the truck. Unpacking would be hellish, but he couldn't wait to get settled. They'd been living out of suitcases in a hotel for the past three days. The house was mostly furnished with their new things, but April didn't want to stay there until their stuff arrived.

"That's just about all of it," she said, consulting a clipboard. She had a checklist of all of their items and had been marking things off as the movers unloaded them. April was a super-organized, type-A kind of girl. He loved that about her. He'd be lost without his wife.

"Sure you don't want to double-check? They might have missed a can opener or something," he teased.

"You mock me now, but you'll be thanking me when your precious pizza stone isn't lost."

“True. What did I ever do to deserve you? I’m starting to think I live a charmed life.”

Jeremy pulled April into his arms and kissed her. The warm, affectionate peck quickly turned into a deep, heated kiss. They’d been on the road, sharing rooms with the kids for a week, which meant no alone time for mommy and daddy. He couldn’t speak for his wife, but Jeremy very much needed some alone time with his wife. She eagerly returned the kiss. Despite her stress, she needed it, too. He couldn’t wait to christen their new house.

“Hey, don’t want to break you lovebirds up, but will this truck be here much longer? I need to get my car out?”

Jeremy reluctantly pulled away from April to find a ridiculously over-pumped guy with a jet-black ponytail calling from the next driveway over. Their new neighbor radiated aggression. An orange polo with “The McLaughlin Auto Group” embroidered on the breast was stretched across his muscular chest. Jeremy instinctively wanted to step back from the man.

“I, uh...” he stammered.

April turned on that sweet, thousand-watt smile that had melted better men than this guy. “So sorry. I know it’s inconvenient, but it’s just so tight back here.”

“Yeah, it’s tight,” the guy said, his full attention turned to her. Jeremy didn’t think he was talking about the cul-de-sac and stood straighter, holding his wife closer.

“They’re just about done, but I can ask them to move the truck if you really need to get out...” She paused. “I’m sorry, I didn’t get your name. We’re obviously your new neighbors. I’m April, and this is my husband, Jeremy.”

She pulled out of his grasp and walked over to their neighbor. The guy wasn’t that much taller than her—she was in stacked, wedge sandals that added three inches to her height—but he was so broad that he dwarfed her. She offered her hand, and the man slowly took it. Over her shoulder, Jeremy saw him giving her a slow once over like he wasn’t concerned about being obvious. April couldn’t like that at all.

“Tommy told me someone was moving in, some guy who works for him. He didn’t mention such a lovely wife. I’m Chase.”

“Great to meet you, Chase. Yes, I’m the wife.” She left out the *lovely* part but didn’t sound annoyed by his flirting. Jeremy couldn’t see her face.

He realized he hadn't moved and joined his wife and her new friend.

"Yes, you are, April. I think Tommy buried the lede. It's going to be great having you here," Chase said, leaving a pause between *you* and *here*. He still only had eyes for April. He also still held her hand. It was like Jeremy wasn't even there.

What the hell? Jeremy wondered. *This guy isn't seriously flirting with April right in front of me, is he?* "Nice to meet you, Chase," he said, interjecting himself.

"Yeah, great to meet you. You two from around here?" Chase was only asking one of them.

"No, we've just moved down from New Jersey for new Jeremy's job. I'm so proud of him." April took his hand with her free one.

"You're gonna need someone to show you around then."

"There's Google Maps," Jeremy said. He wanted to wave in the guy's face to remind him he was there. Chase might have been trying to look down April's dress.

The cute, colorful maxi dress wasn't low cut, but it might have flashed something if she leaned forward. April didn't hide her body but didn't dress to flaunt it either. Jeremy always thought that was a shame and encouraged her to dress up when they went out. She had a body that deserved to be shown off.

"That would be great. I'm sure your *wife* could suggest some good local shopping," she said, noting Chase's large, gaudy wedding ring.

"You're not out here harassing them about the truck, are you, Chase? You're the boss. You can go in whenever you want."

The voice belonged to a woman walking out of Chase's house. It was like April had summoned his wife. Jeremy's jaw dropped. He had to cut his new neighbor some slack because he couldn't stop staring at the woman who'd just appeared. The slender, raven-haired wife was one of the most beautiful women he'd ever seen, besides his April, of course. She was tall—but that could have been her heels—with silky hair that fell almost to her waist.

"Nah, I'm just introducing myself to our new neighbors. This is April," Chase said, still flirting with her, even though his wife stood right there.

"I'm Richelle, but you'll end up calling me Shelly. Everyone does."

April pulled her hand away from Chase's big paw. "I'm April. It's so nice to meet you." She shook hands with Richelle.

"And you're?" Richelle asked.

"Oh yeah, sorry. I'm Jeremy. It's been a long day." He snapped out of it and took her slender hand. It was impossibly soft.

"Hi, Jeremy. I want you to know that we're here for anything you need. It's so important for neighbors to be close, isn't it?"

Richelle had deep, dark eyes with a slight feline tilt. Jeremy lost himself there for a second. He didn't see women who looked like models in his everyday life. He quickly recovered—he hoped—and said, "Yeah, I... we...look forward to getting to know you guys."

"We'll have to have you over for drinks," Chase said, directing the invitation at April.

"That would be great, but we have two little ones. We always have to plan around them," April said.

"Fantastic! How old are they? Ours are ten, seven, and four."

No way she's pumped out three kids, Jeremy thought, checking out his neighbor's tight body. Her leggings and tank top didn't leave much to the imagination. Richelle dressed how he wished his wife would. He was sure Chase would say the same about April's body. She'd always been fit, going back to her high school cheerleader and pageant days. Kids didn't change that, except she maybe had an even better ass.

"Gabi is nine, and Gabe is six," April said.

"Gabi and Gabe! I love it!" Richelle exclaimed.

"You'll need to join their mommy club," Chase said, somehow making it creepy. "All the women on Milford Court are moms."

"That's wonderful," April replied. "I was hoping there'd be other families here."

"Mrs. Sampson?" One of the movers called out. "Would you like to go over everything? We're getting ready to wrap it up."

"Yes, Sean. I'll be right there," she called back over her shoulder. "It was great meeting you guys. Let me get back there, so we get this truck out of your way, Chase. I'm sure we'll be seeing you again soon."

"You can count on it," Chase said.

"Wonderful to meet you guys," Richelle said, pulling Jeremy into a surprise hug. He You can go in whenever you want."

The voice belonged to a woman walking out of Chase's house. It was like April had summoned his wife. Jeremy's jaw dropped. He had to cut his new neighbor some slack because he couldn't stop staring at the woman who'd just appeared. The slender, raven-haired wife was one of the most beautiful women he'd ever seen, besides his April, of course. She was tall—but that could have been her heels—with silky hair that fell almost to her waist.

"Nah, I'm just introducing myself to our new neighbors. This is April," Chase said, still flirting with her, even though his wife stood right there.

"I'm Richelle, but you'll end up calling me Shelly. Everyone does."

April pulled her hand away from Chase's big paw. "I'm April. It's so nice to meet you." She shook hands with Richelle.

"And you're?" Richelle asked.

"Oh yeah, sorry. I'm Jeremy. It's been a long day." He snapped out of it and took her slender hand. It was impossibly soft.

"Hi, Jeremy. I want you to know that we're here for anything you need. It's so important for neighbors to be close, isn't it?"

Richelle had deep, dark eyes with a slight feline tilt. Jeremy lost himself there for a second. He didn't see women who looked like models in his everyday life. He quickly recovered—he hoped—and said, "Yeah, I... we...look forward to getting to know you guys."

"We'll have to have you over for drinks," Chase said, directing the invitation at April.

"That would be great, but we have two little ones. We always have to plan around them," April said.

"Fantastic! How old are they? Ours are ten, seven, and four."

No way she's pumped out three kids, Jeremy thought, checking out his neighbor's tight body. Her leggings and tank top didn't leave much to the imagination. Richelle dressed how he wished his wife would. He was sure Chase would say the same about April's body. She'd always been fit, going back to her high school cheerleader and pageant days. Kids didn't change that, except she maybe had an even better ass.

"Gabi is nine, and Gabe is six," April said.

"Gabi and Gabe! I love it!" Richelle exclaimed.

"You'll need to join their mommy club," Chase said, somehow making it creepy. "All the women on Milford Court are moms."

“That’s wonderful,” April replied. “I was hoping there’d be other families here.”

“Mrs. Sampson?” One of the movers called out. “Would you like to go over every- thing? We’re getting ready to wrap it up.”

“Yes, Sean. I’ll be right there,” she called back over her shoulder. “It was great meet- ing you guys. Let me get back there, so we get this truck out of your way, Chase. I’m sure we’ll be seeing you again soon.”

“You can count on it,” Chase said.

“Wonderful to meet you guys,” Richelle said, pulling Jeremy into a surprise hug. He willed himself not to get a boner when her body pressed against his. “Hope you don’t mind, Jeremy. I’m a hugger.”

“Uh, no, why would I mind? I’m a hugger, too.”

“Good to know, buddy,” Chase said, clapping Jeremy on the shoulder so hard he stag- gered. He called out to April. “Don’t you worry about the truck, honey. Take your time.”

“Thanks, Chase,” she beamed. “I really appreciate that.”

Jeremy watched their neighbors go back into the house, relieved they were gone. That was one of the weirdest encounters he’d ever had. He went from being pissed that Chase was all about April to mooning over Richelle so quickly that he almost got whiplash.

He flushed the hot new neighbor from his mind by standing back and admiring his wife. Chase may have an incredible piece of ass at home, but Jeremy got why the man was so taken with April. Most guys were, and she had no idea the effect she had on men. He suspected she really did but wouldn’t admit it. Anyway, she truly was a marvel. She was the complete package. Beautiful, funny, sweet, has an edge, etc.

April was outgoing and people had always flocked to her. Jeremy understood all of that is easier when you’re pretty, and his wife had always been the kind of pretty that stops guys in their tracks. Her brown hair was always shiny, and her deep hazel eyes offered a playful hint of mischief. She had a cute button nose and bee-stung lips. She was more of the girl-next-door type—not the model type like Richelle—but the girl-next-door who gives you all the dirty thoughts.

She was a high school and college cheerleader, participated in the pageant circuit, and even represented their home state at a national competition. But none of that ever went to her head and turned her into a stuck-up bitch. The thing he

loved the most about his wife was that she was the most down-to-earth, kindest, level-headed person he'd ever met. April was who you wanted in a crisis. She could diffuse any situation with her warm, calming vibe. No wonder Chase backed right down when she approached him.

Jeremy watched April go into the house with the mover, admiring the sway of her ass in that maxi dress. He was glad he had as much fire for his wife now as he did when they met fourteen years ago.

He wasn't the only one admiring his pretty wife. Jeremy had been aware of the movers checking her out all day. Rather than blame them, he was proud. He always got a charge when men noticed April. The only reason Chase pissed him off was the open flirting, but even that was kind of hot—especially because she seemed to like the attention.

April had one more fan. Before turning to follow her into the house, Jeremy saw another of their new neighbors outside. The huge Black man seemed to watch her with as much naked interest as Chase had. He looked like he wanted to split Jeremy's petite wife in half. Jeremy wondered if he'd have to fight men off down here in Florida. It wasn't like the Miami-Dade metro area had a shortage of hot women. It was known for that.

The Black man watching his wife was familiar, but he couldn't put his finger on why. He was older, maybe in his fifties, but he could have been a former athlete. The man looked like he could still run out onto a football field. He caught Jeremy looking and offered a friendly nod as if he hadn't been watching April's ass.

Are all the men here so aggressive? Jeremy wondered. He'd have to up his game to fit in. He tipped his head back and followed his wife into the house, feeling protective and aroused.

two

April felt like she'd accomplished a lot that afternoon and evening—until she looked at how much there was left to do. They'd left so much behind. How could they still have so much stuff? April felt like she'd never finish unpacking. Their last move was supposed to really be their last. They'd found their dream home, or hers anyway.

Their house in Hamilton was close to both their parents. They had great friends in the neighborhood. And April made the house hers over the years. It seemed that Jeremy had not felt the same way, but she knew he was a striver when she married him. April was ambitious, too, but felt they had enough. Her parents had taught her that a simple, modest life was a good life. If you had excess, you were supposed to help people. Conspicuous consumption was not her thing.

Everything about their new home screamed *conspicuous consumption*. Why did a house in South Florida need a gas fireplace? They had one set into a beautiful white stone fireplace with a glass front. A huge TV, left by the last homeowners, was mounted just above it.

The kitchen and dining room were both oddly small like they weren't designed for people who ever cooked or ate in. *Rich people probably eat out every night*, she thought cattily. The dining room had black walls, which April would be repainting at her first opportunity. The bedrooms were similarly decorated with a stark, modern flare. She looked up at the high ceiling in the living room and foyer and wondered how she would clean it. All

of it was very pretty, but none of it matched her taste. Turning the luxury house into their home would be an ongoing project.

April appreciated one bit of luxury—besides the pool and the Jacuzzi. The master bath was spectacular. It was huge and not only had a tall, freestanding jetted tub but a large, open grotto-style shower area tucked around a corner like it was a secret. She dreamed of passing the kids off to Jeremy and disappearing into that tub for hours.

The kids were in bed, and April decided she'd done everything she could for the day. She was exhausted. Jeremy had done his best to help, but that mostly amounted to carrying and opening boxes or keeping the kids occupied. He was in the way otherwise. She decided where everything went—even his stuff.

Jeremy wasn't one of those husbands who did nothing around the house, but sometimes she wondered if he half-assed chores so he wouldn't have to do them again. It was easier just to do things herself than explain them to her husband. That was unfair. He was a good man who she loved very much. He doted on her and was dedicated to their family.

Taking care of the family was his primary reason for making them pick up and move 1200 miles away. Even if he made partner at the law

firm, Jeremy would never make the kind of money Tommy Siegel offered him. She still didn't know why Tommy—he insisted April call him *Tommy*—had singled out her husband.

She just didn't need as much *everything* as her husband. She wanted to get dirty in her backyard garden on a cool spring morning, not worry that the community's landscapers were getting heat stroke in the hot Florida sun.

Checking the locks before bed felt unnecessary now that they lived in a gated community with private security, but old habits die hard. April went around the house, turning off the lights. She poured herself a glass of wine before heading back to the master bedroom, ensuring there was wine in the house before anything else.

The kids were in the two small bedrooms in the upper part of the split level. The master suite was off to the side and had its own private patio that sat on the artificial lake behind their house.

Jeremy was on the bed, scrolling his phone. April resented that he was just lying there, but that was just because she was tired. He'd had a long day, too. They split bedtime duties, as they often did. He got Gabi, the easier of their children, because Gabe demanded mommy.

"How did it go?" Jeremy asked. He looked up from his phone, saw her sip from the big glass of wine, and added, "Oh, I see."

"Gabe was fine. I only had to read *Goodnight Moon* three times. I'm just generally exhausted. Today was a lot."

"Yeah, it was. There's just so much to do around moving an entire household. I feel like I'll be looking for things for months."

Jeremy set his phone aside and beckoned her to sit beside him on their new, huge king bed. The large birch headboard and footboard made the bed feel like a sanctuary. April picked it out. She sat, and he turned her.

"Ohhh, that feels nice," she sighed as he rubbed her shoulders. Her husband gave the best backrubs. It was why she kept him around—other than being the father of her children. She sipped her wine and surrendered to his tender touch. "Mmm, you can go harder, babe."

"That's what she said," he snickered.

"Really, Jeremy? Is this 2010? You're such a dork. Don't ruin the moment."

"I thought you loved that I'm a dork."

"I do, babe, but less dorking and more shoulder rubbing."

April melted under his firm, insistent hands. He swept her chestnut ponytail aside and rubbed her neck, and she was ready to marry him all over again. Jeremy always seemed to know just what she needed. She could never be so in tune with another man.

"If I were lying down, I'd be asleep already," she murmured. He worked his hands up her sides, careful not to tickle.

"We don't want that."

"We don't? I think it's all I want."

"Is it really *all* you want?"

She realized his hands were doing more caressing than massaging. It all felt good, but now she understood he had an ulterior motive. *Why can't guys just rub your back without trying to get their hands up your shirt?* she wondered, snorting a laugh. He wasn't *always* trying to get laid when he gave her a backrub, but it was often enough. She chose to ignore his passive-aggressive attempt to coax sex out of her.

"You're right. I've been dreaming of that giant bathtub all day. I thought I was too tired to run a bath, but it might be just the thing I need. I hope the box with the towels is in there."

"It is. I opened it."

But of course, you didn't unpack it, she thought. She wasn't angry, but just thought, *Men.*

April finished her wine and slipped away from him, setting the glass on the nightstand. It had gone right to her head after an exhausting day and only having a couple of slices of pizza over the last few hours. They'd learned the hard way that getting pizza delivered to a gated community was complicated. She didn't mind being a little tipsy. It felt nice.

"You know," he said, straining to sound casual, "we haven't christened the house yet."

"Really? I hadn't even thought of that." April played dumb very well. She kissed his forehead and disappeared into the bathroom.

The recessed lighting in the opulent marble-tiled space was dimmable, so she set it low. She felt like she was in a spa. The fancy spigot took a moment to figure out, but she got the hot water running into the deep tub. She was thankful for the step beside it. She didn't know how she was supposed to climb over the high sides without it.

April stripped off the baggy t-shirt and running shorts she'd changed into for unpacking but left her hair up in the ponytail. When Jeremy

didn't follow, she peeked around the corner into the bedroom, careful to hide her naked body from view. He was on the bed, sullenly looking at his phone.

He's probably looking for porn. Is he planning to rub one out while I'm in the bathtub? April giggled. She wasn't one of those wives who was upset if her husband masturbated or looked at porn, although she understood that she probably didn't want to know what kind of porn he looked at. They were not a porn-sharing couple. She was confident she was fun in bed, but that didn't extend to watching porn together. Although, if he ever asked she would try it.

"Well, are you going to follow me?" she asked.

three

Jeremy dropped his phone so quickly that it tumbled off the nightstand onto the tile floor. Luckily, it landed face-up and didn't crack on the hardwood. He threw his clothes off and raced into the bathroom to find his nude wife waiting beside the enormous white porcelain tub with one foot on the step beside it. She smiled because she knew he would follow. Her smile said, *What took you so long?*

They'd been married for twelve years, but Jeremy still had to pinch himself when he saw April naked. He'd been with pretty girls before her and sexy girls, but his wife was everything in one package. She had the sweet smile and demeanor of a Midwestern schoolteacher, so seeing her in lingerie or nude was always a surprise, like he was seeing something forbidden.

Her tight body was all creamy white skin—she was very careful with the sun—with a fit but not insanely toned body. Her ass was a sweet peach but not rock hard. Her tits were high and perky, but not giant rounds. She was girl-next-door hot, which drove men crazy. They all wanted to corrupt her. Jeremy loved that.

He also loved being the only one who knew his wife wasn't the perfectly pure Sunday School teacher type she appeared to be. She didn't want to be tied up or hung from the ceiling, but she had a fun, sensual side.

April held out her hand, and he helped her step into the tub. A calming aroma floated up with the steam, telling him she'd added one of her bath oils. She settled into one end and stretched out. The water lapped at the pale rose caps of her perfect handfuls.

A neatly trimmed delta darkened her pale skin where her thighs pressed together. Jeremy willed April to open her thighs to expose her pink. Her head was barely above the top lip. She looked tiny in the oversized tub. He couldn't tear his eyes from her and felt life pulsing into his shaft.

"Did you come in here to just stare at me? You've seen it all before."

"I'll never get tired of seeing it, honey." Jeremy grinned.

She laughed. "You say that now. Get back to me in a couple more years when I'm in my forties."

“Never. It’s been almost fifteen years, and every time is like the first time.”

“I can see that,” she said, staring at his rising member. Her eyes sparkled. He’d always appreciated that April got a little horny after a couple of glasses of wine.

“Didn’t you think I’d be tired of you when you got in your thirties and had a couple of kids?”

“I was, like, barely out of college then. I didn’t know anything. Thirty-five seemed impossibly old. And now I’m closer to forty. Oh god, I’m a hag!” She laughed again, making her tits jiggle. Jeremy could watch that all night. April had the best laugh. The best tits, too.

“You’re a MILF, and you know it.”

“Don’t you dare! I do not need or want to be a MILF. I don’t need young guys with a weird fetish chasing after me. I’m relieved I never have to go out with a college guy again.

Or any guy. Dating sucked.”

“That’s because you have the perfect guy, right?”

“Of course. Although, if you don’t get in this tub with me right now, I might have to make a Tinder profile and try my luck.”

“Let me be clear. I’m getting in because no man in his right mind would refuse that invitation. Not because I believe you’d actually make a Tinder profile.”

“Hey, I have secrets. I could surprise you.”

“I’m sure you do,” he replied, entering the tub, careful not to step on his wife. “But I’m certain you’re not looking for flings on an app.”

April tried smiling mysteriously. It was just adorable. “Think what you like.”

Jeremy turned off the water and settled back on the other side of the tub, their legs intertwined. He liked that they had a tub big enough for two. On the rare occasions they tried this in their old house, they were so squished together that it was uncomfortable, not sexy. He liked rubbing legs with April and looking at her wet, naked body. This was more confirmation he’d made the right call to take Tommy Siegel’s job offer.

She purred and rubbed her legs against his. “I need to get a pillow for this tub,” she sighed, leaning back and closing her eyes.

“Order one from Amazon tomorrow. Anything you want, honey.”

“You know, you don’t have to spoil me, babe. I’m not saying to stop, but you don’t have to.”

“I never will, April. Nothing makes me happier than seeing you happy.”

Jeremy’s balls ached while he watched his sexy wife at the other end of the tub. He’d have to take care of himself tonight if she didn’t do it. But she wouldn’t leave him high and dry. She was many things, but a tease wasn’t one of them. He wouldn’t be in the tub if they weren’t going to make love. He just needed to let her relax for a minute first. She’d let him know when she was ready. He passed the time by watching his wife and entertaining the idea that she’d been serious about Tinder.

The men of the Miami-Dade area would be lucky if April put herself out there. He thought of *Real Housewife* types when he thought of the women of Miami. Richelle next door could be a *Real Housewife*. He also thought of hot Latinas, but he didn’t think they had many women like his wife down there.

Yeah, the guys down here would kill for a shot at April, he thought. *I don’t care what she says. She’s a MILF, and she knows it.* Just thinking about the men of Miami chasing his wife made Jeremy’s cock unexpectedly surge, and he had to resist the urge to touch it. He’d always gotten a dirty tingle when men noticed April, but he never went as far as thinking about her doing anything with them.

Jeremy blamed their new neighbor, Chase. That squat bull definitely wanted a shot at April. Ordinarily, he’d be surprised, considering what the man had at home, but he understood cheating wasn’t about that—and Chase seemed like the type that would cheat. April and Richelle were completely different types. Chase had probably never had a shot with a woman like April—not that he had any shot now. But seeing someone like Chase aggressively undressing April with his eyes stirred something inside Jeremy.

April didn’t tell Chase he was a pig and walk away. That was part of it. She was polite to a fault but didn’t tolerate boorish behavior. She had plenty of chances to dispatch guys like Chase back in Jersey. They were everywhere. But April stood there and smiled while their neighbor flirted. She might have even blushed under the heat of his lascivious gaze, but it could have been the actual South Florida heat. It was late June, and the heat and humidity were oppressive.

Did she like Chase flirting with her? Jeremy didn't even want to consider it. That just wasn't how his wife was wired. She didn't court the attention of other men. She did not want a married man flirting with her and would scorn any man who openly flirted with a married woman. But that was exactly what happened with Chase, and April smiled. She let him hold her hand. The man ignored Jeremy, and she didn't intervene at all. She liked the attention. He was sure of it. *Does she think Chase is hot?*

The idea was absurd. Even if April wanted another man's attention, it wouldn't be someone like Chase. He had to assume that if she would be attracted to another man it would be someone like him, not a brute like their new neighbor.

He and Chase couldn't be more different. Jeremy was in good shape—he'd been a lacrosse player in high school and college—but he didn't look all 'roided up like Chase. April always said she loved that he didn't hide from his emotions. Chase didn't seem like he had real emotions, except maybe anger and lust.

No. No way April would ever let an ape like Chase lay a paw on her. Jeremy was sure of it, even as he thought about how insanely hot Richelle was. Their new neighbor couldn't be more different from his wife, but he would have given his left nut for a night with a goddess like Richelle. *If I wasn't married, of course, he justified. But I'm a guy. We're just like that. April isn't.*

Why couldn't he stop thinking about it if it was so impossible? *Could April want to try something—someone—different? Does she have a fantasy about someone like Chase the way I'm thinking about Richelle?* An image of Chase's big mitts all over his wife's petite, pale body flashed through Jeremy's brain, and a shiver ran through him. *Jeez, I need to get laid and get some rest.*

"What are you thinking about?" April asked, snapping him out of his trance.

"Uh, just thinking about everything. How it's all different. About our new neighbors."

"And here I was hoping that was because you were thinking about me," she said with a soft, bubbly laugh. She ran her foot up the inside of his thigh and grazed his bobbing dick.

"Oh, this is all about you." He groaned when her toes teased him.

“Sure it’s not about Chase? You said you were thinking about our neighbors. Is there something I should know about you, babe?”

“Chase does not make me hard,” he defensively replied, adding an uncomfortable chuckle. He wasn’t homophobic but didn’t want his wife to think for a second that he was into guys.

She knowingly smiled. “Or is it Richelle you were thinking about? You can tell me, babe. I won’t be mad. I know you must be attracted to other women.”

“This sounds very much like a trap. *Uhhh...*” His cock throbbed when she stroked it with her toes.

“Not a trap, I swear. Have you ever known me to be jealous?”

It was true. April was one of the most self-possessed women he knew. Jeremy chalked it up to her pageant days. A woman had to be confident to walk across a stage in a bikini and be judged. He’d fight anyone who didn’t give her a 10.

“Richelle is sexy, but I swear this is all about you, honey. I’ve been dying to give it to you for days, and now we’re finally alone.”

Her lips pouted. “Poor baby. Sorry moving all the way down the East Coast got in the way of you getting laid. You should have just grabbed me in the shower one morning.” She rubbed his shaft more aggressively with her foot.

“With the kids right there in the hotel room? Yeah, you would have gone for that.”

“Never know if you don’t try, babe.” She gave a knowing smile.

Sometimes, she hinted at kinkier depths than they’d ever explored together, but he did not think his down-to-earth wife would have gone for shower sex with their kids a few feet away. He didn’t know if he could have done it either.

Jeremy decided to turn the tables, slipping his foot between her thighs and pressing her mound. April moaned and escalated by pushing at him. She held his foot in place with both hands and squirmed to get into the right position. His heel was snug against her furrow, and she rubbed against it. She was so hot and slick that it was apparent in the steamy tub. His balls tightened. April was driving him crazy. He loved this sexual side of her and wished they had the time to explore it more often.

“Have you been thinking about Chase?” he asked, adding more pressure with his heel. She sank lower in the water and spread her thighs to

rub back harder.

April wickedly smiled. "It's all for you, babe."

"I don't know. Chase was very forward, and you didn't seem to mind at all."

"Are you accusing me of flirting with another man?" She feigned indignation.

"Were you flirting? I didn't say that. And that's not a denial."

Playful light danced in her eyes. She used both feet to rub him. It was a first. He'd never had a foot job before. "I think maybe I should take the fifth."

"I'm not the jealous type either."

April snorted. "Right. You always act funny when guys pay attention to me."

"I do not. *Mmm...*"

Jeremy felt like she was trying to tease a confession out of him. She was quite good at using her feet and cute little painted toes. That was a strange thing to learn fourteen years into a relationship. *Did she perfect this on someone else?* he wondered.

April wasn't a virgin when they met, but she didn't have a laundry list of former lovers either. She could count them on a single hand, with digits to spare—as far as he knew. She could have fudged her numbers a little. That was a thing women did. Something tickled the reptilian part of his brain when Jeremy thought of his sweet wife using her petite feet to jerk off some guy in college.

"*Always*, she stressed. "I don't mind because you're not a jerk about it. I think it's kind of hot that you're so into me. *Ahhh...*"

"It's all about you," he grinned.

"Shouldn't it...*ahhh...* be? You always say I'm your princess." She rhythmically rubbed herself on his heel. She was so into it that she'd given up teasing him with her feet.

"Are you going to come, *Princess?*"

"*Are you...ahhh...*"

"That's not what I want, April."

Jeremy grabbed her hand from the tub's edge and pulled April to him. She eagerly climbed on top, smothering him with kisses. He wrangled her, slipping her his tongue. She ground into his lap, moaning into their kiss.

She may have been even hornier than he was. He was thrilled. They had a great sex life, but he hadn't seen his wife like that in a long time.

She reached between them. Her grip on his shaft was tight. She sank onto it. *"Ahhh...yesss..."* she gasped, tearing her lips from his.

"Shit... April..." he grunted. She was tight around him, like her hot sleeve was milking him before she started moving.

"Ahhh... babe..." She began moving on him.

Her slow, sensual rhythm said she wasn't in a hurry. She wanted to savor their love-making. Jeremy held her waist but let her remain in control. He liked it when April was on top. Watching from underneath was incredible. This wasn't that, but he still loved it when her sexuality reigned. Her head hung back, and she worked her core. The little swivel she added to her hips made his heart race.

"You...did...like...him flirting..." Jeremy grunted.

"Shut up...did not...ahhh..." Her sheath rippled around him when she denied it.

"You...uhnn...liked the way...he...looked at you..."

April gripped the sides of the tub and started riding harder. Her back arched, thrusting her tits at him. Jeremy enjoyed their bounce for a moment before capturing them. He rolled their tight rose tips just hard enough to make her hiss. She loved gentle caresses but didn't mind if he got a little bit rough. He was confident he knew just what his wife liked.

"Ahhh...AHHH..."

"Uhhnn...god...you did...you liked it..." Jeremy grunted his accusation.

"Shut up...ahhh yesss...shut up...god baby..."

April still rode him when her loud cries echoed through the marble-tiled bathroom. The space made her orgasm deafening. She could be vocal—they'd both learned how to be quiet since having kids—but she rarely lost it like that. The heat of her molten core pulled Jeremy right along with her. She came to a shuddering halt, and he tightly gripped her waist and jammed up into her. He erupted, jetting his seed deep inside his smoldering wife.

They kissed fiercely. April felt like she was trying to climb inside of him. She trembled in his arms, and her sheath rippled around his shrinking cock. Jeremy thought her

pussy was a marvel. All the energy drained out of her at once, and she sagged into him. He held her tightly.

“That was great,” he huffed, playing with her wet ponytail.

“Mmm, I’ll admit it. You weren’t the only one who needed it.” She sighed contentedly. “That was very good, babe.” She laid her head on his shoulder.

Jeremy shrank enough to slip out of her and had a realization. They hadn’t used protection. “April, we didn’t think. Was this a good time?”

“Silly man. Who’s the most organized person you know? We’re good for a couple days.” She laughed and kissed his neck.

“Of course, you knew.” Jeremy squeezed her tighter.

It was a silly question, but he hadn’t thought to pull out, and April didn’t make him either. Even a little drunk and a lot horny, she knew her cycle. She couldn’t use hormonal birth control, and at thirty-eight, she wasn’t positive that she was done having kids, which took an IUD off the table.

They’d used the rhythm method as long as they’d been together. April made him use a condom during the danger zone when they were younger, which Jeremy had always hated. Sometimes, she’d just blow him, but that wasn’t a real solution because April still needed sex. She seemed to crave it even more when she was ovulating.

After thirty-five, she compromised and let him pull out in those ten days. Jeremy didn’t just blast away. He usually finished on her stomach, but it still felt hot and naughty to come on his sweet wife. She’d never admitted it, but he thought maybe she liked it too. However, in the twelfth year of their marriage, it could be too easy just not to do it for that stretch of the month.

“What was with all the talking, babe? That’s not like you,” she said, idling, tracing her nails on one side of his neck and softly kissing the other.

“No idea. Sorry.”

“Don’t apologize. It was fun. I’m open to trying new things. You know that. It just surprised me. For the record, that was all you, babe. I wanted to make love to you. I wasn’t thinking about our dumb neighbor.”

“I know,” he replied, thinking of how her pussy clenched when he taunted her with Chase. He wouldn’t press her on it. April could have her secrets. Besides, it was surprisingly hot that flirting got her going.

“Really, you just surprised me. Dirty talk could be fun. Just think of something more realistic.”

“I get it. I love you, honey.”

“Love you more, babe. Always.”

four

April got packing as early as she could motivate herself the next morning. Jeremy was out the door while she was still in bed, off for his first day at Stirling Sports Management. She tried to convince him to stay in bed with her, but even stroking his cock didn’t do the trick. Jeremy returned to kiss her goodbye, saying, “No rest for the wicked.”

Their fun encounter in the tub the previous evening left April feeling a bit wicked. She couldn’t recall the last time they’d done it anywhere but in bed. They weren’t boring, but they had fallen into something of a routine. It was only to be expected after twelve years of marriage. But making love in their amazing new bathtub wasn’t why she felt wicked.

Dirty talk wasn’t like them. Neither were foot jobs, to be fair, but April felt extra playful in the tub. She blamed the combination of exhaustion and wine—not that being sexually playful was bad. It felt good. She’d always had a naughtier side that she had difficulty exploring.

Jeremy loved her, but she always feared being judged if she seemed *too* slutty. Sometimes, she wondered what it would be like if they experimented in the bedroom, even a little bit. He never tried to push things in bed, either, which made them a good match. That was precisely why she was so surprised by her husband’s weird teasing about their new neighbor, Chase.

April admitted nothing to her husband, but did she flirt back with Chase? She didn’t think so. Was a man being so openly interested in her exciting? Well, maybe...

Guys paid attention to her. She knew it. They’d been paying attention since a young age. She had been a pretty, precocious kid. Boys started

noticing her after that and she attracted crushes—many unwanted. April always tried to be nice, even when guys didn't want to hear that she wasn't interested.

She would have never gotten on a pageant stage if she didn't know she was attractive. But that came with a freighter load of insecurities and body image issues. Winning pageants never went to April's head. Men still noticed her, even though she was a mom-of-two in her late thirties, but they didn't give her the kind of *fuck me* eyes she got from Chase anymore.

He was not her type at all, but she responded to his bravado. He had one of those heavily muscled physiques one only gets from spending hours in a gym with a trainer and a ton of creatine—if not other help. His broad chest looked like it might have burst his overworked polo if he moved wrong. His thick arms were covered in tattoos down to his wrists, and his ponytailed hair was much too black for a man his age. None of that should have worked for her, but Chase pulled it all together in a package that got her attention.

April decided it was because she had captured his attention. The primal part of her just reacted to a powerful man like Chase coming onto her. It was like pheromones, but it didn't mean anything. How could it, when he had such a stunning wife? But she could still be pleased that someone like Chase turned the hot light of his desire on her.

None of that explained Jeremy's reaction. He obviously felt disrespected by Chase, but that wasn't why he brought it up during their tub time. He didn't sound jealous or angry. He teased her, but it sounded like Jeremy *liked it*. When she was on top, he was clearly turned on, thinking she flirted back with their new neighbor. She had to be wrong. It made no sense. Men do not get turned on when their wives flirt with other men. Not that April was flirting. She had to stop navel-gazing and get to work unpacking.

The morning peace was broken when Gabi called out from upstairs. "Mooommm!" Her daughter's shout was joined by Gabe, and soon, the children were calling for her in a chorus. "Mooommm!" April sighed, threw back the covers, and climbed out of bed.

She was hardly on her feet when the kids rushed into the bedroom and flung themselves at her. She wanted to know how they slept in their new beds, but they all collapsed into a laughing mess on the bed.

April was sweating, even with the central air pumping. She'd been at it unpacking ever since she got the kids fed and parked them in the living room with their tablets. They settled down with a promise they could go in the pool later. She could already see the pool was going to be a problem. She loved a pool as much as the next girl, but the kids could not spend every waking moment in it. April hoped the novelty would wear off.

The morning was spent concentrating on unpacking upstairs. The kids would be more settled when their rooms were set up. She and Jeremy would also be more at home in their room when their familiar things were around them. They brought virtually no furniture from their old house, but April kept as many of their things as possible.

Jeremy's insistence that they see the new house as a blank slate annoyed her. She understood that much of their old furniture didn't match the new house, but she liked their big sectional couch. It was lived in, having been broken in by the happy couple the night they got it. They'd made so many memories in that house that discarding all that furniture like it meant nothing hurt her.

And then there was the expense. She felt like they were spending obscene amounts of money. Jeremy was thrilled to throw money around because of his fancy new job, but it seemed wrong. She was too practical to spend money for the sake of spending money.

The great toy unpacking had just finished when the doorbell rang. The new house came with a loud chime that played something intricate and familiar, but she couldn't place the tune in doorbell form. The chime was followed by a shouted chorus of, "Mom! Somebody's at the door!"

April couldn't imagine who could be at their door. They didn't know anyone in Florida. *Maybe it's Chase looking for a cup of sugar*, she thought, with a smile. She could tease Jeremy with that later. April hoped it wasn't their muscular neighbor. She was a mess, and even though it didn't *really* matter, no woman wanted to appear like that in front of a *somewhat* attractive man. She pushed sweaty hair that had escaped her loose ponytail back from her forehead and went to answer the door.

Richelle waited on the other side of the door with a woman April hadn't met. Neither woman was empty-handed. The stranger held something in a casserole dish, and Richelle had a Bundt cake on an ornate plate covered in cling wrap.

She was surprised. Richelle didn't seem like the domestic baking type.

"We're not interrupting, are we?" Richelle brightly asked.

April plastered on a smile even though they clearly were. "It's okay. I could use a break. Why don't you two come in?"

"Don't worry, we won't stay long. I remember how awful moving was. I swore I'd never move again after last time," her neighbor replied.

"I always say the same thing. Let me know if you need a hand with anything. It's April, right?" the other woman said. She had the slightest hint of a South American accent. April couldn't place it.

"Sorry. I'm such an airhead. April, this is Cami. Cami, April."

"So nice to meet you, Cami. Please, both of you, get in here. You must be wilting in the heat."

"Oh, you'll get used to it. I hardly notice now," Richelle said, breezing past her.

"She's lying. I grew up in Columbia, and I still hate the tropical heat. My dream is to live somewhere hot and dry like Arizona or Vegas."

"Stop it," Richelle said, giving Cami's arm a warm squeeze. "You know we love you too much here ever to let you leave. The guys would never have it."

"They need to remember they don't own me."

Both women laughed and April hoped the exchange meant that there was a warm community they'd be accepted into. At that moment, she felt out of place in her own home. She was a mess, with no makeup, wild hair, and wearing just a tank top and soccer shorts. The other women were both Instagram-ready.

Richelle was just as gorgeous as she'd been the day before. Her raven ponytail was sleek and tight. The woman's hair was just as black as her husband's, but didn't look like it came from a dye kit the way Chase's did. Colorful athleisure hugged Richelle's long, flawless body, triggering April's catty side. She was glad Jeremy wasn't there to see the beautiful woman again. She didn't want to stare for confirmation, but she swore the bumps of Richelle's nipples in the tight top looked pierced.

Cami was just as stunning. Both women had dark good looks, but while April was sure Richelle was part Asian, Cami was all Latina, with the fantastic curly hair to go with it. Richelle was tall, but Cami was compact, which meant she was all curves, which a tiny, flouncy sundress did little to

hide. She could see why the neighborhood men wouldn't want her to leave, April thought, her cattiness slipping out again. Cami was curvy but just as fit as Richelle.

April was in good shape, but standing near her neighbors made her want to hit the gym. She was sure Jeremy would be just as happy to meet Cami as he'd been to meet Richelle. *Are all the women in this neighborhood models?* she wondered.

"Oh my gosh! Look at these two angels!" Cami exclaimed. "What are your names?"

"I'm Gabe," April's youngest proudly announced.

"I'm Gabi. Wow, your nails are so cool."

April did everything she could to teach her nine-year-old daughter that looks didn't matter and that she didn't have to be a girly girl, but Gabi still gravitated to that stuff. Of course, she noticed Cami's nails. Gabi always wanted April to do hers.

"My Lucia is just about your age. Maybe you can come over, and we can have a nail party—if your mom says it's okay," Cami said.

"Mom, can we?" Gabi was so excited that she barely contained herself.

"We'll have to see, honey. We don't want to make a nuisance of ourselves."

"Anytime! We love a glamour party at my house," Cami said.

April forced a smile. Cami seemed nice, but she was the last person April wanted her daughter imprinting on. "You guys keep doing what you're doing. We'll be in the kitchen if you need anything."

They didn't actually go into the kitchen. She was thinking of their old house with the large, eat-in kitchen. The three women could not comfortably fit into her new kitchen standing, let alone have a place to be seated. She took her neighbors' housewarming offerings and asked if they'd like coffee. Richelle said bottled water would be fine, but Cami was happy to accept a cup of coffee. Both women declined an offer of the Bundt cake.

"When you're my size, every extra bite shows up," Cami said, patting her stomach.

"I know you always need to be camera-ready, but you're being ridiculous. Guys love you because you're curvy," Richelle told her friend.

Cami laughed. "Easy for you to say with a body like that, Shelly."

“Who cares anyway?” April offered, carrying coffee and half and half out to the table in the breakfast nook that overlooked the manmade lake behind the house. “Look how you want to look. If you want a piece of cake, have a piece of cake.”

Richelle gave her a lengthy once-over. The hostess felt judged. “Don’t tell me you don’t watch what you eat. Not with a body like that, April.”

April felt her cheeks heat up. “I try to eat healthy and work out, but I’m not watching everything that goes into my mouth. I don’t think that’s healthy. I had enough obsessing about my body during my pageant days.”

“Shelly couldn’t possibly watch everything that goes into her mouth,” Cami snickered.

“Very funny. I seem to recall you were right there with me the other night.”

It was like the women were speaking a secret language. Neither of these perfect women was stuffing their faces. Did they both have eating disorders? She didn’t want her daughter to grow up around people so focused on physical appearance.

“Of course, you work out, April. You’ve got a terrific little figure,” Richelle said, re- turning her attention to the hostess. She seemed about to say more but stopped herself.

“And you totally have a heartland, beauty queen vibe. I bet you won all the crowns!”

“I did okay. I won in my little suburban town and then the county. I made it to Miss New Jersey,” she humbly admitted. “Yes, I’m a Jersey girl, not a Midwest beauty queen.”

April was proud of her accomplishments, but sometimes, she was embarrassed that she was so into the pageant circuit when she was younger. There was a time when it was one of the most important things in her young life. She would put on her competition bikini every day for weeks before a pageant and model it in the mirror to make sure it fit right. She didn’t have a full-blown eating disorder, but her relationship with food was *not* healthy. Her current workout regimen was about staying healthy, not how she looked in a swimsuit. Well, it was *mostly* about staying healthy.

“Do you still have the sashes and crowns? I’d love to play dress-up,” Cami said excitedly.

“They’re in my old room in my parents’ house in New Jersey. Should I have them sent down?” April laughed. She did not mention that her parents kept her room like a shrine.

“Well, you could still win a crown if you tried, April. You’re adorable! I’m sure all the men in your old neighborhood just ate you up, and their wives were jealous. Do you go to the gym every day?” Richelle complimented.

“Thanks, Richelle, but no, the men were not *eating me up*, and my friends were not jealous. It wasn’t like that. I went to the gym back home and ran in our neighborhood. I like to do 5k runs, but I can’t imagine doing that here. I’d die of heat stroke.”

“It’s Shelly, please. I love my name, but I know it’s a mouthful. I do 5ks. It’s not so bad down here once you’re acclimated to the heat, you’ll see. Maybe we could run a race together.”

“That would be great, *Shelly*.”

“If you like the gym, you’ll love the one at the club. We have world-class facilities here,” Cami said. “We have a home gym, but I still try to get over to the club a couple of times a week.”

“I remember seeing a gym over there, but honestly, I don’t remember much from our original tour. It feels like we were in a rush because we just flew down for the day. My parents had the kids but couldn’t keep them overnight.”

“When you’re done unpacking, or if you just want to get out, I’ll be your tour guide. I’ll show you everything here in Peregrine’s Nest. There’s so much to do. Sometimes it feels like there’s no reason to leave at all,” Cami said.

“You have to go grocery shopping,” April laughed.

“Oh, the housekeeper does that. If you need help, I can make recommendations.”

“We know all the best nannies in the community, and we know when they’re looking to move on,” Richelle added.

“I never had a nanny or a housekeeper,” April said, hoping she didn’t sound judgmental. She’d never thought of having either. “I was able to do my work at the non-profit back home around the kids’ schedule.”

“Well, think about it. Having a little help makes things so much easier,” Cami replied.

“If you’re looking to do charity work down here, I have contacts with some wonderful causes,” Richelle said. “So does Marti. As a public figure, she is involved with a lot of groups. They always want her to come and MC something. You’ve met Marti, haven’t you?”

“I haven’t.”

“Sorry, I just assumed because she’s Tommy’s wife.”

“No, we’ve only met Tommy. He flew up when he was negotiating with Jeremy.”

“Tommy is in New York a lot for work. I know that. Those two definitely couldn’t get by without help since they have little ones again. I couldn’t believe Marti wanted to re-up. The two oldest ones are adults, but now she’s got ten-year-old twins,” Richelle said.

“But she’s got endless energy. That woman puts the rest of us to shame,” Cami added. “You’ll love Marti when you meet her. Everyone does.”

“I doubt you’ll have to wait. I’m sure Tommy and Marti will have something to welcome you guys to the neighborhood,” Richelle said.

“Not too soon, I hope. There’s still so much to do around here.”

“It’ll all get done. I know it seems overwhelming now, but take it one task at a time,” Cami said, taking April’s hand. She seemed very sweet. The woman added, “But it would go so much faster if you had help!”

“Why don’t you send Viktoria over,” Richelle suggested. “I’d send Izzy, but she’s busy with the kids.” She took April’s other hand and winked at Cami. “I only have a nanny who does light housework. I don’t have as much help as Cami.”

“I’m very busy, you know that. I can’t have the kids walking in when I’m trying to work.”

Richelle laughed. “That would not be good. Cami is a budding entrepreneur. She is actually very busy with it. The beast always has to be fed.”

“It’s not work if you love what you do,” Cami said.

April felt like the women were talking around her. They were so tight that she wondered if she’d ever fit in.

“Anyway, you’re going to love it here, April,” Richelle said, turning back to the hostess. “And everyone is going to love you. I just know it. I’m sure you’re going to fit right in.”

“Shelly’s right. I know the gang is going to love you. And if you can relax and go with the flow, you’ll find the community has so much more to offer than you could have ever imagined.”

“You guys make it sound like paradise.”

“It can be if you want it to be. You just need to be willing to take everything that’s offered,” Richelle said.

“And now you’re making it sound like a cult,” April laughed.

Both women squeezed her hands and laughed, too. She couldn’t remember the last time two strangers held her hands. Maybe in church? Her new neighbors were both so lovely, but they were so different from her. She didn’t know how she’d ever fit in with them. Maybe she needed to do what Cami suggested and just go with the flow.

five

Jeremy sat in his office chair and stared out the window at the stunning view. The bay was a placid expanse of sapphire between Bayfront Park and some island where a cruise ship was loading. If the island had a name, he didn’t know it. Just being in an office with that view was surreal. It was a world away from his windowless cubicle in an anonymous office building in Central Jersey.

Being a guy, Jeremy had never been wined and dined before, but this experience with Tommy Siegel felt like a whirlwind romance. Did even a month pass between when he and April met Mr. Siegel at that work function, and he was shaking hands on the deal for his new job?

Jeremy still didn’t fully understand why he was recruited so hard. His ego insisted he deserved it, but he understood it was unusual for a mid-level attorney at a successful but average firm to be recruited as in-house counsel for a company like Stirling Sports Management out of nowhere. Mr. Siegel just wasn’t a man you told no.

He had checked in with April throughout the morning to see how the unpacking was coming. He felt guilty that he couldn’t be there to help. She replied with a thumbs up and an *xo*, which meant she kept her spirits up.

April said the neighborhood welcoming committee appeared on their doorstep. Jeremy was disappointed he missed seeing Richelle again, but

he was glad his wife was already making friends. The sooner she was accepted into the community, the sooner her anxiety about rebuilding their lives would ease.

“Do you need anything, Mr. Sampson?” his assistant asked, poking her head through the doorway.

“No thanks, Liliana. Not until I have something to do, but I appreciate it.”

Liliana had only stuck her head through the doorway, but he saw all of her because the outer wall of his office was glass, and his blinds were pulled aside. He felt like he was sitting in a fishbowl, but the view of Liliana was nice.

He’d never had an assistant before, and she was a hell of a first. The stunning Latina had hair down to her waist and wore a lowcut pastel dress that looked painted onto her curves. It was the kind that had strings hanging from the sides as if it could be pulled even tighter. That dress would have never passed muster at his old law firm. Liliana was like a walking Miami stereotype.

Jeremy noted that all the women working in the office, including the agents, looked like they’d been chosen from a model catalog. He didn’t think he’d ever seen such a stunning collection of women anywhere, let alone in an office setting. Even the girl from IT who came in with his laptop and login information was nerd-hot.

He thought he might be too distracted to get any work done with Liliana sitting just outside his office and immediately felt guilty for it. April would smack him if she knew he’d thought it. He suspected his wife’s professed lack of jealousy would be tested when she met his new assistant. He would have sent her a photo as a test, but that would have been creepy.

“How are ya, honey?” boomed from outside his office. “Keeping the new guy in line?”

Tommy Siegel stood by Liliana’s desk in all his tanned, buff glory. He wasn’t overinflated like Chase, but Mr. Siegel was in amazing shape for a man in his mid-fifties. Jeremy only guessed at his age. The man may have been younger but weathered because he obviously spent a lot of time in the sun. He was the polar opposite of Jeremy’s smooth, pale wife. April avoided the sun like a vampire.

Liliana smoothly slid out of her chair again and walked into Jeremy’s office. “Mr. Siegel is here.”

“I can see that.” He clearly saw his boss, who stared at her lush, round ass. He wanted to add the obvious, *the wall is glass*, but didn’t. Liliana stood there until he added, “You can show him in.” Jeremy didn’t know how assistants worked yet.

Liliana stepped aside, but not far enough to avoid Mr. Siegel brushing against her. The older man looked like he might grab her ass too. Jeremy wondered if he needed to ask the girl if she felt safe, but Liliana didn’t look at all upset. *Do all the men in Miami be- have this way?* he wondered, recalling how Chase visually stripped April. He’d been thinking about that on and off all morning.

“Jeremy, my man, how’s it hanging?” Mr. Siegel beamed.

“It’s, uh, hanging good.” Jeremy rose from behind his desk and offered his hand. Mr. Siegel’s handshake was crushing, but he smiled through it.

“Settling in okay?”

“Yeah, I guess so. I don’t have anything to do yet, so settling in is pretty easy. All I’m doing is hanging,” he replied with a nervous laugh.

“I thought we’d ease you into it, champ. I’ve got a stack of contracts for you to go over before training camp, but I didn’t want to overwhelm you on day one. You played sports, didn’t you?”

“My whole life, Mr. Siegel. I played lacrosse and soccer in high school and lacrosse in college. I still played soccer in a league back home before we moved.”

Tommy Siegel made a face. Jeremy recognized that look. Back in his younger days, the guys who played football—even baseball—didn’t see soccer or lacrosse players as being tough like they were. He suspected Mr. Siegel had been a football player. He had the build of a fullback, short and strong like a pit bull. Jeremy knew that was bullshit. Lacrosse could be brutal. Soccer was rough, too, when played with intensity. He’d spent a lot of his life in locker rooms and knew how to fit in, but felt like Mr. Siegel was always trying to out-macho him.

“Please, call me Tommy when we’re alone. I told you that. We’re neighbors now. You can’t run around calling me Mr. Siegel back home, unless you’re nasty.” He paused, and Jeremy laughed at the old Janet Jackson joke as required. “But you should probably call me Mr. Siegel out in the office when other people are around.

“Anyway, I like to think of us as a team here at Stirling. And that means we need to think of ourselves as athletes. I expect everyone here to go balls out and leave it all on the field. But like good athletes, we need to warm up first, and that’s what I want you to do, champ. You get what I’m saying, don’t you?”

“Yeah, sure, *Tommy*. I get it. I just know you’ve shown a lot of faith in bringing me on, and I want to make sure I live up to your expectations.”

Tommy smiled. “Trust me. I know I’ll get everything I expect out of you, champ. I wouldn’t have brought you down here to Miami if I wasn’t sure of that.”

Why does that sound ominous? Jeremy wondered. Everything about his new boss was intimidating. He stiffened his spine to show he was just as tough as Mr. Sie—*Tommy*.

“Hey, we’re having cigars and drinks on my desk after work today. Why don’t you come up and join us? It’ll be a good chance to meet the other partners.”

Jeremy was about to say he had to get home because April had been unpacking and watching the kids all day, but he suspected how that would go down with his boss.

“That’ll be great. Sure.”

“See you then, champ.” Tommy started to leave, paused to leer at Liliana from behind her back, and told Jeremy with a chuckle, “Hey, try to stay out of trouble down here.”

Jeremy gave him a two-finger salute and immediately felt stupid for doing it. At least he was invited for cigars with the big wigs. He didn’t smoke but was excited for it. He’d text April. She’d understand. Tommy Siegel’s office was three floors above Jeremy’s and three times the size, which made sense. When he arrived, happy hour was in full swing, like the party had started well before five o’clock. People spilled back into Tommy’s office, but most of the action was out on the deck. Music blared from outdoor speakers, and the pungent smell of cigar smoke hit Jeremy the moment he arrived.

He awkwardly wandered around the huge office. He wasn’t going to rush to Tommy’s side like an excited little puppy. It would seem like he was sucking up. Luckily, the happy hour was full of distractions.

Tommy’s walls contained signed jerseys and game balls from almost every major athlete of the last twenty years, intermingled with photos of

the boss with all the men in every conceivable setting. More than a few showed him on the sidelines or courtside at championship games. The display conveyed one message: this man is a legend. Jeremy thought it odd that he'd never heard of Tommy Siegel until a few months before.

"Can I get you anything, Mr. Sampson?" It was Liliana. She touched his arm and stood very close.

"Oh hey, Liliana, I didn't know you'd be here." He felt less special about his access to the boss if assistants were also invited.

"Mr. Siegel lets some of us come up. He says it's good for team building." Liliana leaned even closer and lowered her voice. "I think he just likes having us around. You know what I mean?"

Jeremy knew exactly what she meant and questioned why it didn't bother her. April wouldn't tolerate that kind of misogyny for a second. Liliana had touched up her makeup. Her lips were ruby red, and she had a flowery scent he hadn't caught before, but he hadn't been so close to his assistant. He was close enough that he had to force himself not to look down the valley of her cleavage. He still spied the lacy trim of a black bra.

"Yeah, I know what you mean. Networking is important," he replied, hoping Liliana wasn't pressed into the sordid type of *networking*. She seemed like a nice girl.

"Now, what can I get you, Mr. Sampson."

"We're off the clock, Liliana."

"It's still my duty to ensure all of your needs are handled."

He flushed under the collar. Was Liliana's smile suggestive? He couldn't let his mind go there. He loved his wife.

"Well, since it is after work, at least call me Jeremy. I guess I'll have a beer."

Liliana's hand had lingered on his arm, and he realized she was caressing it. He knew he should put some space between them, but he didn't move. "I suggest you have one of Mr. Siegel's bourbons. They're all very good."

Looking around, Jeremy realized no one at the happy hour was simply having a beer. He nodded and was thankful Liliana was there to help him through the strange protocols of his new company. Stirling Sports Management was a world away from the uptight protocols of his old law

firm. He couldn't imagine anyone drinking in the office—not openly, anyway. This was some wild *Mad Men* stuff.

When she handed him his drink, Jeremy was relieved to get away from Liliana and felt guilty for it. The amber liquid smelled like lighter fluid, and he winced. He wound through the people in the office and onto the deck to find Tommy. The humid Miami evening was an oppressive wall at the threshold. He was instantly sweaty and felt he should have at least taken off his tie before coming up. He stood out as the only person wearing one in the office all day anyway. Stirling was not a shirt-and-tie kind of office.

Tommy Siegel held court at the center of a semi-circle of chic white outdoor furniture in a front corner of the spacious patio. He had women on either side of him and three men hanging on his every word. One of the women was a perfectly coiffed redhead in a tight, low-cut pastel sheath. Jeremy suspected she was an agent. The other woman was Asian and dressed similarly to Liliana but impressively managed to show even more skin. She had to be another assistant.

"Jeremy, my boy! Get on over here, champ!" Tommy called out, waving when he spotted him.

"Mr. Siegel," Jeremy replied with what he hoped was a masculine nod. He remembered the boss was *Mr. Siegel* in front of others.

"Hey, make room. This is the new hotshot legal guy I brought in, Jeremy Sampson." The men didn't move until Tommy glared. A spot was made, and Jeremy dropped into it. The men were all shoulder to shoulder. "That's Graham. He handles our soccer guys in Europe. I guess you two have something in common. I don't get you soccer guys. Phil specializes in golf pros. And Sammy handles *problems* for us if you catch my drift."

Sammy was the thick-necked, graying brute of a man on the end. His powder blue sports shirt looked expensive but was still ill-fitting, and his black slacks were a size too tight. The man was red in the South Florida heat. He sized Jeremy up in about a second. "I make sure there are no problems, capisce? I'm sure we'll be working together if you're the legal boy."

"Uh, yeah, whatever you need," Jeremy replied, hoping his fear of the man didn't seep through. He didn't want to have anything to do with a thug like that.

“This here is Whitney,” Tommy said, leering at the redhead to his right. “She’s in client acquisition. She’s very good at her job.”

Whitney shot Tommy a look and said, “My job is not what he’s implying.” She winked and placed her hand high on Tommy’s thigh. “But I guess sometimes it helps to let them think it is.” The blonde’s smile made Jeremy think he’d agree to anything she wanted.

“And this lovely lady is her assistant, Cassandra,” Tommy continued. His hand was high on her thigh. She said *hi* and waved.

The boss and his two women looked like they could slip off for a threesome at any minute. Jeremy wondered how Mrs. Siegel would feel about that. “Jeremy here just moved down from Jersey. He and the lovely Mrs. Sampson are also my new neighbors.”

Sammy snorted. “Only good things about Jersey are *The Sopranos* and poorly secured landfills.”

“You guys moved onto Milford Court? *Oh*,” Whitney said.

“Is there something wrong with Milford Court or Peregrine’s Nest? Seems like a great community,” Jeremy asked.

Whitney looked at Tommy and hurriedly replied, “No, it’s great. I wish I could get a house in Peregrine’s Nest. I hear it’s a very tight-knit community. I’m sure you and...”

“Adorable April,” Tommy answered before Jeremy could speak.

“I’m sure you and April will find your groove and fit right in. It’s exciting to have a new adventure, isn’t it?”

“Yeah, it’s a lot of change all at once, but April and I are up for an adventure. Can’t let life get boring, right?”

“That’s what I love about you, champ. You’re always open to an adventure. That’s how I know you’ll fit right in. To adventure!”

Tommy raised his glass, and everyone followed. Jeremy drank with everyone else and only just managed to avoid choking on the acerbic bourbon, hoping everyone would chalk up his redness to the heat. He was not a hard liquor kind of guy. Everyone else downed their drinks like pros. Jeremy hoped he could keep up. He wondered how long these happy hours lasted. April was still waiting for him at home.

April went ahead and fed the kids because she was tired of waiting for Jeremy to come home. Her texts asking where he was went unanswered. The last she heard from him, Jeremy said he was stopping at Tommy Siegel's office for a quick drink after work, but he didn't expect to be late. She didn't even ask why they were drinking in the office.

Gabi was occupied with her tablet, and Gabe played with Legos while April collapsed boxes and carried them outside to the curb with the trash. Peregrine's Nest had strict rules about when trash could be placed at the curbside for pickup and how quickly cans had to be retrieved in the morning. Appearance was everything in the exclusive community. She tried to take it in stride, but it rubbed her the wrong way.

That would be her last work of the day. Afterward, she would give the kids baths and get them to bed—without Jeremy's help. Her husband had better have a good excuse for not being home to help and being unreachable. She was sure he'd been busy on his first day at the new job, but she'd been busting her butt all day, too. She needed a break. She wasn't angrier because one glass of wine with dinner had turned into two and a half.

April admired the fluffy clouds hanging in the brilliant orange and pink sky while she dragged cardboard to the curb. She had to admit that the South Florida sunsets were glorious. One of these mornings, after everything was settled, she'd get to the beach for an early morning run and see the sunrise over the ocean. Living so close to the beach was a benefit to their new home.

"Hey, neighbor!"

The deep voice startled her, and turning too quickly caused April to trip over the large sheets of cardboard she dragged. She stumbled but would have caught herself, but large, strong hands cradled her hips, effortlessly sweeping April off her feet. The stranger set her down, his hands moving higher to her arms.

"Thanks, I'm good," she said, twisting away from her rescuer. She did not feel she needed to be rescued.

"Just wanted to make sure. I'd feel terrible if I let you fall to the pavement."

"You have good reflexes."

April caught her breath and finally took in her knight in shining armor. The Black man was gigantic. She stared him in the chest before she

looked up. A heavy, diamond- encrusted, golden “82” hung from a thick chain around his neck. He had to have close to a foot on her height, and she was not a short woman. Her eyes traveled to a flawless, charming smile framed by a meticulously groomed mustache. The man was ridiculously handsome. A warm tremor ran through April. He was the kind of man that provoked that reaction in women.

“I’ve been told I have good hands,” he chuckled.

“I guess you do.” She stared at his massive mitts, thinking they could encircle her waist. His wedding band looked like it could be a bracelet on her. The man was a mountain, like the football players she’d known when she was a college cheerleader, except none of them had this stranger’s physical presence.

“Made a career out of it. I’m Darius. I’m just across the way over there.” He pointed to a house on the other side of the cul-de-sac. Like the Siegel’s house, it was bigger than hers.

“Hi Darius, I’m April. This is me,” she replied, pointing behind her and feeling silly for doing it.

“Let me get that for you.”

“You don’t have to. It’s just cardboard. It’s not heavy.”

“A man doesn’t just stand by and watch a lady struggle,” he said, ignoring her complaint and brushing by to lift the cardboard bundle.

April watched him and admired the way Darius moved. His tank top and shorts looked tailored to show off his impressive physique—not that it could be hidden. *That man would look built in a full suit*, she thought admiringly.

The cardboard was heavy enough that it was hard to grip and drag with her much smaller hands, but he lifted it like it was a sheet of paper. She followed and watched him deposit the bundle at the curb beside their trash cans and an additional row of trash bags. She had been busy.

“Thanks again. If you do windows, you might be my new hero,” she said.

Darius smiled, sending another warm shiver through April. She blamed the wine, but the handsome man just oozed charm. “Always streak-free, baby.”

“You’re hired.”

“Damn, you’re quite the worker bee. You only moved in yesterday, right?” He

whistled while looking at all the waste her unpacking had produced.

“It has to get done, right? I like an orderly house.”

“Woman after my own heart. Everything has its place. Is it so hard to put that plate in the dishwasher? Clutter in your living space clutters the mind.”

“Your wife must be very happy,” she replied, thinking, *he’s too good to be true.*

“She’s well taken care of in every way.”

The look in his deep brown eyes suggested Darius could take care of *all* April’s needs if she’d like. And that was the too good to be true part. Surely, his wife would not appreciate her husband flirting with a neighbor. Although, Richelle didn’t seem to mind when Chase flirted with her.

Is there something in the water here? Are all the men oversexed? April wondered. *Jeremy better not get any ideas from these guys. I’m not going to tolerate that kind of behavior.* Her lack of jealousy had its limits.

April may have considered the flirtatious men of Milford Court inappropriate, but just like with Chase, she found herself appreciating Darius’s attention. The next-door neighbor was not quite her type, but a built man like Darius was every woman’s type. *My head isn’t going to fit through the door if I keep having these encounters with such handsome men.* Men like Darius didn’t even exist back in her old world, let alone look at her like that.

He poured over April like he wanted to toss her over his shoulder and carry her home. She couldn’t suppress the forbidden tingle such a possibility stirred in her. She’d been in the backless, black one-piece since she’d gone in the pool with the kids earlier and had just pulled shorts over it. The bathing suit wasn’t anything special, but Darius admired her figure like she was showing it off in a string bikini.

His possessive gaze made her feel naked in the best way. She self-consciously touched her ponytail, wishing she’d done more than just throw on a baseball cap and pull her ponytail through the back. April was hardly a femme fatale. She looked like the typical suburban mom she was, but the handsome stranger made her feel like a sex kitten. It didn’t matter that he had to be at least a decade older than her. Part of her kind of liked that.

The two-and-a-half glasses of wine let her indulge the feeling. It was harmless anyway. Nothing would happen. April allowed herself to admire

him right back.

“Is she, uh, waiting for you at home...over there?” she asked, pointing at his house. *Does that sound like I hope she's not?*

“Nope, Peyton's out with Marius. I think it's one of those baby gyms, Mommy and Me, or something like that. I'm all alone. Is Mr. April in there? I know you didn't move down here all by yourself.”

The comment only reminded her she was angry Jeremy wasn't home yet. “No, he's still at work. I'm all on my own.” *Does that sound like an invitation? God, I really am flirting back, just like Jeremy said. Serves him right for not being home.*

“A smart man doesn't leave such a pretty wife home alone. All kinds of things can happen.”

Darius's voice was lower, seductive. She felt like she was falling under a spell. *Did he move closer?*

“This neighborhood is safe, isn't it?” Her voice sounded low and breathy in her ears.

“I've got my eye out, April. I'm always around to take care of you if he's not. You don't need to worry about being alone.”

Okay, you need to get a grip, girl. This isn't just smiling for a flirting man. He wants to come inside. That was when April remembered she wasn't actually alone.

“I'm, uh, not alone. The kids are inside. I really should get back in there. It's bath time.” *Using the kids as a shield. Lamé.*

His smile widened. “Gotta love a dedicated mom. Almost as much as I love bath time.”

“I really need to go,” she replied, backing away. “Bath time.”

“Yeah, you said that. I got things to do, too. Keep takin' care of business, April. And anything you need, I'm right over there. Don't forget.”

“I won't. I promise.” *Why did I promise? Stop acting like a crushing teenager!*

“Go on then, April. Get inside. Want to make sure you get in safe. Goodnight.”

“Goodnight, Darius.”

April knew he was waiting so he could watch her leave. She'd never admit she threw an extra swish into her hips when she went back inside to her kids.

seven

Jeremy stumbled out of the hired car with a helpful push from Liliana. He hoped April wasn't looking outside when he closed the door. His wife was already going to be furious. He thought it would be worse if she saw him with his assistant. Liliana wasn't a secret, but that wasn't the night to tell his wife about his hot new assistant.

Maybe it won't be that bad, he thought. It wasn't like he was stumbling home after midnight. He knew it was sometime between nine and ten. If he was lucky, April was already in bed. Ordinarily, she was the early-to-bed, early-to-rise type. She had to be tired if she'd been unpacking all day. He tried to be quiet and slowly pushed the front door closed.

The house was mostly dark, which was a good sign, but that meant Jeremy tripped over everything in his unfamiliar new surroundings. He cursed when banging his shin, but April didn't call out. She was a heavy sleeper. He made a pit stop in the kitchen for a drink of water before steeling himself to head back to the bedroom.

Jeremy chose to leave the lights off and try to navigate the dark bedroom by the light coming in from the sliding door to the small, private deck off the master bedroom. The South Florida night was bright, but the room was still shrouded in shadows. He didn't see his wife in bed, but the room was chilly with the pumping central air, and she'd probably pulled the comforter up over her.

Staring hard, like it would magically give him night vision, Jeremy slowly stepped

through the bedroom. He navigated a box on the floor and a chair that he swore was in the middle of the room. The master bath was the destination. He would take a hot shower, slip into bed, and April would have no idea what he'd been up to. He wasn't entirely clear on what had happened that evening, anyway. Events became blurry after his third bourbon and the cigar Tommy forced on him. He vaguely recalled Liliana lighting the stogie.

He was just about to the bathroom when he was caught.

"Nice of you to drag yourself in, Jeremy," April called out in the dark. He jumped and nearly fell over.

"Sorry, I was trying not to wake you, honey."

"I wasn't sleeping. I was worried."

April was not in bed. She must have been sitting outside on the patio. She stood in the doorway with the sliding glass door open. He couldn't tell how annoyed she looked in the darkness. She was framed by the moonlight behind her, highlighting her figure through a short cotton nightie. *Is she trying to make me feel like I missed out?* It worked.

"I left a plate for you in the fridge. Do you want me to warm it up?"

He knew she was playing the martyr and didn't take the bait, still hoping to slip into the bathroom and shower before his wife got too close. "That's okay. There was food at Tommy's thing." He backpedaled toward the master bath.

"Oh, it was a thing? I thought you were just stopping up for a drink."

"Yeah, a drink. Or two."

April closed on him and he knew he wouldn't escape. He paused at the sliding barn door. She stood close and sniffed.

"God, Jeremy, you look awful, and you smell worse. Were you smoking?"

"I didn't inhale." He knew it was lame the moment it left his lips. He acknowledged her disbelief, adding, "Tommy's a cigar guy. I felt like I had to, but I really didn't inhale. I was choking on the smoke."

"*I did it because of peer pressure* sounds really lame coming from a forty-one-year-old man."

"I know. I'm sorry, honey. Let me get a shower, and it rinse it off me."

Jeremy tried to turn, but April caught him by the untied tie that hung around his neck. She sniffed again. His wife was turning into a

bloodhound. "Is that perfume?" she asked.

"I, uh, dunno, Maybe? I shared a car home with a coworker. It must be from that," he lamely babbled.

"It must be? Why else would you smell of perfume, Jeremy?"

The evening's details were foggy, but he didn't do anything with Liliana or any of the other women hanging around in Tommy's office. Jeremy was clear on that. He kept all of his important body parts to himself. But Liliana might have been in his lap at one point? He wished he could say no. She definitely helped him down to the car with her arm around him. And she sat *very* close in the car. Unnecessarily close. But Jeremy was sure he didn't lay a finger on his hot assistant.

"Yeah, I'm sure that's what it is. These Miami girls are, like, all made up all the time. But you don't have anything to worry about, honey. I don't care how hot they are. They're no competition for you."

April snorted. "I'm glad none of them are *hot enough* to compete with me. Not even Shelly?"

"Shelly?" Jeremy asked, trying to shrink away from his wife. She was four inches shorter than him, but she was still scary when she got like that. He was pressed against the barn door and had nowhere to go.

"Richelle. Are you sure I'm *as hot* as she is? I guess I'm going to have to up my game now that I'm one of these *Miami girls*."

"Come on, honey. You're perfect the way you are. You don't want to dress like that or wear all that makeup and stuff. I love you just like this."

"Just like this?" She stepped back and posed, showing off her nightie.

It was one of his favorites. Simple, but sexy. Just like his wife. Her soft brown hair was brushed out and seemed to glow in the moonlight. He couldn't imagine April in a dress like Liliana wore to the office. She didn't need to flaunt it like that. He'd take his wife over all that eye candy at the office any day.

"Yeah, you're so pretty, April. God, sometimes my chest gets all tight when I look at you."

She seemed to soften for a moment but said, "Maybe that's not the only part of you I want to make tight. Maybe I want the kind of attention these *Miami girls* get."

Jeremy thought she was going to smack him, so he was truly stunned when April grabbed him by the tie, pulled him down, and kissed him. It was a hungry kiss he hadn't received from her in a long time. He returned

it but otherwise froze in shock. She let him go just as quickly, leaving him breathless and swaying.

“God, you taste awful, too. What were you drinking? No more cigars, understand?”

He was ready to agree to anything she wanted, but April grabbed him for another kiss before he could speak. He gradually recovered from his shock and touched her, hands landing on her hips before sliding around to grab her ass. His wife had such a nice ass. Firm enough but with a sweet jiggle. That ass looked incredible in a pair of tight jeans.

It felt like she didn't have panties under the nightie. His excitement surged and he battled her tongue back with his. But before he could reach under the short garment, she turned them and shoved him toward their bed.

April pushed hard, and he fell backward, bouncing on their new mattress. She liked sex but never got that aggressive. He was horny because he'd been around the hot women in Tommy's office all night, but what was April's excuse? She stood between his legs and wrestled his belt free.

Jeremy was confused when she pulled out his semi-flaccid cock. He *felt* ready. He'd been ready all evening. He'd had on-and-off erections from the time he walked into Tommy's office. But he was not ready to go when his wife grabbed him. She squeezed and jerked it, almost too rough in her impatience.

“Don't tell me you don't want it,” she whispered in the darkness.

She knelt on the bed and leaned over to kiss him again. He tasted wine through the miasma of cigar and bourbon in his mouth. That explained some of her horniness. April was fun when she drank. He palmed her hanging breasts through the thin cotton nightie. Her warm rounds filled his hands, and she moaned when her excited tips burrowed into his grasp. Jeremy focused there, and she attacked harder with her tongue.

He thought she was fired up in the tub the night before, but this was next level. *Did Chase come over to flirt again?* he darkly wondered.

“Come on, babe,” she moaned, pulling back but keeping her hand on his shaft.

Give me a minute, he thought. Jeremy was getting hard, but slowly.

April was impatient. She stunned her husband by ducking down, pushing her hair back, and taking his cock into her mouth. It wasn't like

she *never* went down on him. She just didn't do it often a dozen years into their marriage. But when it did happen, it was usually after a couple of glasses of wine.

"*Ahhh...Ape...*" he groaned, his entire body surging, not just his dick.

She worked his shaft with her hand, like every experienced cocksucker does, and attacked the head, sucking and swirling her tongue. April was always quite good at giving head—something he'd always chosen not to think too deeply about. He needed to get her to do it more often.

He grew in her mouth, and she sucked harder, swallowing more of him until her lips met her hand. April had to be very drunk to deep-throat him. Blowjobs were usually a tease before the main event. But her eager sucking was more than enough without pushing to the back of her throat.

She slowly bobbed on him, and he pushed her hair back, cursing the dark room. The bedside lamp was frustratingly out of reach when he stretched for it. He wanted to watch her do it.

Watching his beautiful wife sucking cock had always been one of his favorite things. She had such pretty, full lips, but the real reason was that seeing his dick disappearing into such a sweet, perfect face felt so dirty. Jeremy was sure every guy she'd been with felt the same way. There was just something extra hot about getting it on with a quintessential girl-next-door type.

His grip tightened on her head when April massaged his balls. *God, I've missed this. She's so fucking good,* he marveled, squinting in the darkness. She sucked harder, and he imagined he saw her staring up at him in the darkness, but it looked like her eyes were closed. *She's so into this!* Imagining his wife badly wanting to suck his dick got Jeremy all the way there. He fully plumped up and stretched her pretty lips.

April released him with a gasp. "Move back," she impatiently urged. He barely finished scrambling back on the bed before she was astride him. For the second time in as many nights, she grabbed his cock and settled onto it with a satisfied moan.

"*Yesss...ahhh...yesss...*"

"*April...honey...god yeah...*"

Jeremy reached for her, but she pushed his hands away. Her hands braced on his stomach, and she pumped her hips up and down,

rhythmically moaning. Her molten slickness scrambled his brain. April was never that wet without foreplay. She'd been in such a hurry to fuck him that his shirt was still in place, and his pants were around his ankles. He'd have been suspicious if she were a different woman. He settled back and watched his sexy wife use his cock. He knew he was lucky to have a woman who wanted to do all the work.

"Ahhh...yesss...yesss...ahhh..."

April took her time like she was determined to extend her pleasure. Watching his wife take total control was unexpectedly hot like watching her flirt with Chase had been. It was crazy because they'd only been there for a day, but it was like living in South Florida was already turning them into different people. April was becoming a daringly sexier version of herself, and Jeremy a man who appreciated it.

"Ape...god yeah...god...do it...yeah..."

She sat straight up and pounded her pussy down onto him, crying out loudly. She threw off her nightie, riding him gloriously naked. The cute bounce of her tits was irresistible. Jeremy reached for her again. April half-heartedly pushed at his hands but didn't fight when he rolled her nipples.

"Yesss...ahhh yesss...AHHH GOD JEREMY!"

He marveled at the sight of his wife climaxing on top of him. Her sheath tightened, and her stiff body seemed to ripple when the pleasure washed through her. April was a goddess when she came. All the bourbon became a benefit because somehow, he didn't come right after her. She kept bouncing on him like one orgasm wasn't going to be enough.

She fell forward but kept moving, sliding against him to thrust back and forth on his impaling shaft. He held her narrow waist and pounded her harder onto his cock. Jeremy couldn't stay passive.

"Uhhh...fuck me...fuck me, Ape...fuck me..." he grunted.

"Ahhh god...babe...yesss..."

"Fuck me, April...you...need it...fuck me..."

"Yesss...yesss...god yesss, babe..."

"Tell me, Ape...say it..."

"Awww...fuck...me...fuck me..." April whined. The words sounded forced, but they were still hot as hell. His wife was not the kind of woman who begged him to *fuck her*. Was she becoming one of *those Miami girls*?

“Ohhh god...April...fuck...ohmyfuck...” Jeremy rushed right over the line. He kept jamming her drenched cunt onto his cock even as he exploded inside her. His jizz made their union slicker, and she tightened around him in response. Her sheath fluttered and then April was coming with him. She pinned his cock deep inside her to take the final blasts of his load where her body craved it.

“Ahhhhh yesss...ohmygod...yessss....”

April trembled on top of him like this orgasm went bone deep. He wrapped his arms around his wife.

“I love you so much, babe,” she contentedly sighed.

“Jeez, April, what got...” he panted.

“Shhh... just let me feel it, babe.”

Jeremy wanted to know what had gotten into his wife—besides him—but wisely shut up.

April stared up at the lazily spinning ceiling fan in the dark. She was naked on top of the sheets, something she never did. Smiling devilishly, she considered she might even sleep naked. Jeremy was asleep. He’d passed out soon after they finished, which was a relief. She wasn’t in the mood to talk. Only now, after the sheen of sweat had dried on her skin and her heart stopped pounding, did she dare question, *What was that?*

Was that angry fighting sex? Was it makeup sex? They didn’t do angry sex, and they didn’t really fight, so makeup sex wasn’t much of a thing either. It was not making love. April was sure of that. It was raw and physical and intense. And she loved it.

Anger was there. She was pissed that Jeremy didn’t wander in until almost ten o’clock, and when he did, he reeked of booze and cigars. *How dare he’s out partying with the boys when I’m home unpacking our lives?* She tried to be understanding because it was his first day, and maybe they were trying to welcome him at work, but then she smelled the perfume on her husband and saw red.

Jeremy was not a cheater, of that she was sure—as sure as a wife could ever be. She understood men and their weaknesses. They only needed one drunken temptation to throw their vows away. It had happened to her best friend. But he loved her intensely. She just couldn’t see that happening. He was too smart to put himself in that situation.

But April did smell perfume, and it set off something unexpected in her. She was not jealous but competitive, and she wasn't above showing her husband he already had the best at home. That competitive spirit mixed with her simmering arousal, and April pounced. Jeremy clearly didn't know what hit him.

When she put on the nightie, her plan had been to tease him and blow him off. It would frustrate her, too, but she'd deal with that to punish him. She'd felt playful all night after meeting their new neighbor, Darius. April chose not to examine that too closely. She was allowed to have a harmless crush. She was married, not dead, as the cliché went. The more wine she drank, the more playful she felt. And the hornier she became. Teasing was not in the cards.

April lay there in the dark beside her lightly snoring husband, blown away by how amazing their sex was. She thought the bathtub sex was good, but this was a new height. *Why is it getting better when it's getting dirtier? Jeremy told me to fuck him! He made me say it, too! God, I begged him to fuck me!* Her core tightened recalling it. But their new sex talk wasn't the dirtiest part.

The shame she felt was silly, but April was ashamed anyway because her mind kept slipping to thoughts of another man while she was with her husband. She closed her eyes when she sucked Jeremy's cock, and for a moment, it was Darius in her mind.

Maybe a harmless crush was okay, but thinking about sucking the neighbor's cock was not—not when her husband was in her mouth. And then, when she rode him and came the first time, Darius was back in her mind, driving her to come harder. April pushed Jeremy's hands away because she was reliving Darius touching her, and his hands were so much bigger than her husband's.

They're just fantasies, she insisted. *It's normal. I bet every woman on this street has a crush on Darius. Shelly's surely done the same thing I did tonight. And Jeremy was probably thinking of her anyway!* April ruefully thought, *She's the kind of woman you tell to fuck you. Not me! Jeremy's never made me say that.* April hadn't begged for it in so long. She forgot how good it felt to be a little dirty. Maybe this was a new chapter in their sex life.

April kept those positive thoughts while wine and exhaustion took over, and she drifted off to sleep. She didn't bother to find her nightie and

slept naked for the first time since that boyfriend in college.

eight

The ladies of Milford Court sat on the patio by the pool, sipping smoothies after the most intense Pilates workout of April's life. She kept up with the other women, but only just. Cami, in particular, had superhuman flexibility.

April wished they'd taken their smoothies inside. The workout class had left her over- heated, and now the blistering South Florida morning had her covered in a sheen of sweat. It had only been a week since the move, which was not nearly enough time to adapt to the sticky, tropical heat. Every day in their new hometown felt like the worst day of summer back home in Central Jersey. The heat didn't seem to bother the other women. They didn't sweat. They glowed.

"This is wonderful," April said, sipping her tropical fruit smoothie before pressing the cool glass to her neck. She peeled back her sweat-slick ponytail away from her skin, but that didn't help at all.

"Carlos knows all the right supplements to add. I swear you're going to have more energy in an hour than you did when you got up this morning," Richelle said.

"There's nothing crazy in here, is there?" April asked.

"Nothing illegal if that's what you're worried about." That was Peyton Russell, her newest neighborhood friend. She was Darius's wife. "Although they're better when they're spiked. Did you get hers spiked, Shelly?"

"I didn't have any of them spiked, troublemaker! The last thing any of us needs after a workout like that is booze."

"Speak for yourself," Cami laughed.

“The natural high is enough for me, thank you very much. The workout is more than enough,” Richelle replied, toasting her own words and sipping her drink.

Peyton laughed. “I seem to remember you reaching for a drink right after a hard workout.”

Richelle shot her friend a strange look. “That’s entirely different, and you know it. There’s a right time for everything.”

April was with Richelle. She couldn’t imagine having a drink after working out. She didn’t know what Carlos would spike a smoothie with, but a shot of vodka in there might just knock her out. The Pilates session wrung her out. She was out of her exercise routine with the move and would have to get back into a groove if she was going to do this with the girls regularly. Richelle was the one who talked her into it. April tried to beg off, but her new neighbor insisted it would be good for her. “You can’t just hang out with the kids all day. We all need grown-up time,” Richelle insisted. She had a point. April was going stir-crazy being in the house for the last week, but at least most of the unpacking was done. Gabi and Gabe were with Izzy, Richelle’s nanny. She was unsure about that but allowed herself to be talked into it, just like the Pilates class.

“And any time is the right time for some things,” Peyton said, letting her straw finally silence her.

“You’re terrible,” Cami said, shaking her head. “But you’re not wrong.”

Peyton Russell was a bouncy, saucy blonde, although her honey-tinged Georgia accent made everything out of her mouth sound sweet, not dirty. April just assumed Peyton was talking about sex. She always seemed to be dropping some kind of sexual innuendo, but girls her age could be like that. April guessed the blonde was in her late twenties, at least ten years younger than the other women, and maybe half her husband’s age. Peyton Russell had *trophy wife* written all over her. Seeing his wife, April was surprised Darius took the time to flirt with her and was proud that he did.

April thought about the brief encounter more than she should have over the last week. Part of her hoped to run into Darius again, and part of her actively avoided it. She thought about his big hands and his deep voice and the implied invitation.

Sitting across from the man's wife stirred guilt. April was sure she could have gone over to the Russells' house for some fun that night—if she was that kind of woman. She had to admit that part of her fantasized that she could be and always had. She'd always wished for the nerve to explore some of her dirtier fantasies but couldn't even share them with Jeremy. How could she ever act on them if she couldn't even open up to her husband?

"Do you have everything unpacked? Is everything in its place?" Richelle asked.

"It's all unpacked, but I'm still organizing and figuring out where everything goes. This house is bigger than our old one. There's so many spaces to fill."

"You poor thing. I've seen Jeremy come home late from work. Are you doing it all yourself?" Cami asked.

"It's fine. I expected he'd have to put in the time to get up to speed at his new job. I'm not working right now anyway, so I have plenty of time."

April didn't truly feel that way. She'd been running nonstop since the move and needed a break. She really did understand if Jeremy had to be at the office late—as long as he didn't come home drunk and smelling of perfume again. *That night was so weird*, she'd thought more than once. But she'd also thought, *And god, it was hot! Maybe he should come home like that again.*

"I hope you guys have at least found time to break in all the rooms."

April nearly choked on her smoothie.

"Peyton!" Richelle chided.

"Doesn't everyone do that? Didn't you, Cami?" Peyton defended.

"What do you think? Of course, we did!"

"Okay, but you still do it in every room," Peyton teased. "I'm not sure if you're the one to go by. It was like a marathon when we moved into our house. I swear Darius was determined to do every room that first night." She closed her eyes and smiled like she was recalling it in vivid detail. A stab of envy made April look away from her.

"Lucky for him, that man has the stamina of a thoroughbred," Cami said, also smiling. April did not need that information to feed her crush.

Do these women share everything? April wondered. She was all for fun girl talk, but there were some things she was not accustomed to

sharing. None of her girlfriends back home had ever asked for details of her sex life with Jeremy, and she would have never shared anything like that anyway! April could just see herself throwing out something like, *You're lucky. Jeremy's been quick lately*. But then, maybe having a man like Darius made a girl brag.

"Don't tell me you and Chase didn't break in all the rooms, Shelly," Peyton pressed.

"Of course we did. You know how he is. He's not quite Darius, so we didn't hit them all in the same night, but Chase was eager to christen the whole house."

Do the others really know how Chase is? Do I want to know that? April might not be ready for this kind of girlfriends. *Everything really is different down here*. But she wasn't surprised by the revelation about Chase's sex drive. The man seemed ready to go at it right in the driveway if she'd responded to his flirting—even with her husband standing right there.

"Well, April? Have you?" Peyton asked.

All eyes were on April, making her squirm. She wanted to tell The Real Housewives of Milford Court to mind their own business—not just because she was more reserved than they were, but more because she didn't want to lie. She felt peer pressure to keep up with these confident, sexy women. April had always been popular, but this felt very much like being invited to the cool kids' table, and she didn't want to blow it.

"We're not as quick as you and Darius, but we're checking off the rooms. Like I said, it's a big house. Jeremy couldn't even wait to unpack the boxes."

April couldn't believe she'd made the confession, but it felt good to play their game. A ball of shame also burned in her gut because, except for the last part, it was a lie.

Their sex life had not maintained the intensity of those first two nights. Jeremy kept after her for a few days, but they were both so busy that they were exhausted by the time he was home from work, and the kids were down for the night. The next time they'd made love was back to their routine.

They fooled around long enough to ensure she was ready, and he slipped it in. The only variation was that her husband had become much quicker lately. He only lasted just long enough for her to finish. She was

ovulating, so Jeremy was pulling out just as she was getting there, which proved a bit unsatisfying. Making love to her husband was good like it always was, but April craved more.

She blamed it on her cycle. April was always horny as hell when she was most fertile. It felt like a curse. If Jeremy hadn't been so busy with work and home with her all day, she would have insisted they christened all the rooms in their new house. She would have pulled him into the pantry for a quickie when the kids were distracted with their devices. He would just need a condom because he was *not* pulling out and blasting all over their canned goods.

"I knew it!" Peyton declared. "It's always the innocent-seeming ones who are the worst. You look like butter wouldn't melt in your mouth, but..."

"Other things will," Cami finished. She and Peyton cracked up.

"Oh my god, you two. Can you behave? Poor April is going to run away and never come back. She's not a shameless hussy like you guys. Seriously, I apologize for these

two. They don't know how to behave in polite company," Richelle chided.

April found herself laughing with the saucy women. Maybe she could learn a thing or two from their loose attitudes. She'd like to be less reserved. She thought she was fun, but in a suburban, let's have a board game night or a girls' crazy night out at the local winery way. Her friends back in New Jersey weren't fun the way these women were. She didn't want to be Peyton—except for maybe getting screwed in every room of the house by Darius—but she could be more daring.

"It's okay, really. I'm not as innocent as I look. It's a curse, but it's a superpower, too. It means I can get away with anything, and no one suspects a thing."

"Really, April? I need to hear more about that," Cami said.

"Don't feel like you need to tell these sluts all your secrets," Richelle said.

"Said the pot to the kettle," Peyton said.

"I am not a slut. I just have healthy appetites," Richelle insisted.

"Wow, you all are like sisters," April marveled. She loved her brother, but she'd always wanted a sister.

Cami took her hand with a look that made her emotional. "You live on Milford Court, so you are one of us now, April."

Richelle rubbed April's back, not recoiling at her sweaty tank top. April was the only one of the women at the table she'd consider fully dressed. She wore a long, baggy tank top over her sports bra and leggings. The other ladies of Milford Court proudly showed off their bodies in just sports bras and leggings or ultra-tight yoga shorts. Cami and Peyton looked like they could burst from theirs at any second, drawing looks from the other people at the Peregrine's Nest clubhouse.

"Welcome to the sisterhood," Richelle said with sincere warmth.

Peyton took April's other hand and added, "Everything that's ours is yours, honey. Anything you want."

The women of Milford Court were way more touchy-feely than any other friends she'd ever had. Their sincerity touched April. She got all choked up.

"Thank you guys. Really. This move has been a lot. I'm lucky to have found a group like you."

"Aww, you really are the sweetest," Cami cooed. She looked emotional, too.

"You are," April replied, feeling silly.

"Well, you're going to have a chance to really be a part of the family," Richelle said. "Has Marti reached out yet?"

"No, not yet," April replied. Marti Siegel, Jeremy's boss's wife, was the only wife on Milford Court she hadn't met.

"I thought she would have. Maybe she thinks Tommy said something to Jeremy. Anyway, the Siegels always have a July 4th bash for the group, and this year, it's in your honor. Think of it as a get-to-know-the-neighborhood kind of thing."

"Oh wow, that's so generous. She doesn't have to do that."

"It's not just about you. Marti loves to entertain," Peyton said.

"But it is," Cami insisted. "We have something really special here on Milford Court, and we can't wait to make you and Jeremy part of the family."

April laughed. "You make it sound like a cult."

"Don't worry, April. No one's been brainwashed yet," Richelle said.

nine

“Do you mind watching the kids for a few minutes?” April called out to Jeremy. “I need to run this casserole over to Cami. I feel like I’ve had it forever. “

“I’m their father,” he replied, laughing. “I don’t think of it as watching the kids like I’m not equally responsible for them. I thought we might go in the pool. I’ll try not to let them drown.”

“Very funny. If you do, you’d better be floating facedown in the pool, too.”

April grabbed the clean dish, slipped into her flip-flops, and crossed the scorching expanse of the cul-de-sac to Cami’s house. Her husband’s BMW wasn’t in the driveway, which meant Marc wasn’t home. April still hadn’t met him. He was a lawyer like Jeremy but didn’t work for Tommy Siegel.

Viktoria answered the door. She looked harried with Cami’s two girls hanging off her. Before April could explain that she was just dropping off the dish, the housekeeper directed her back into the house. She smiled and went inside.

The Santiago-Goldman house layout was similar to hers but felt more like a labyrinth because it had a few more rooms. Viktoria took the kids back into a great room, and April turned down a long hallway that only led back to the master bedroom in her house. At the end of the hallway, the door to the bedroom was open, but her friend wasn't there. Sounds came from behind a door to her left, and when she gently knocked, it creaked open.

Cami was on top of a rounded device that roared like an outboard motor. Behind her was one of those folding partition screens draped with scarves. At first, April thought the thing under her friend was some sort of exercise equipment, but when she came further into the room, that illusion was shattered. She was getting a workout, but it was not exercise.

The beautiful Latina was having sex with the large device. She straddled it and thrust up and down on a dildo that jutted from the top. Cami hadn't noticed she wasn't alone because she was fixated on the tripod-mounted camera in front of her. She turned dials on a box tethered to the device before setting it aside. The device rumbled louder.

April opened her mouth but was stunned into silence before a word escaped. Nothing in her thirty-eight years of life prepared her for what she encountered. Her friend was using the most elaborate sex toy she'd ever seen—not that she had experience with sex toys.

Cami was nude, except for a skimpy, see-thru black and red bra that was barely up to the task of containing her bouncing breasts. Her flowing black hair was blown out in perfect beachy waves, and her makeup was, well, *slutty* was the only word April could think of. She stared at the camera with a lusty, desperate expression. Cami looked like April had felt recently—like all she wanted was a body-rocking orgasm. She worked her powerful hips, driving her pussy onto the sex machine.

“Oooooo yesss...my needy pussy is sooo full...gonna come so hard for you, darlings...”

She was obviously vamping for the camera. A fuzzy microphone was clipped to one of her bra straps. But she wasn't lying. April saw the sex machine's vibrating shaft glistened with Cami's arousal. She *heard* how wet her friend was when she thrust up and down. Cami grabbed both her bouncing breasts and whined when she roughly pulled her own nipples.

“Oooooo...I need an extra set of hands...but my husband's always working...who can help me...”

For a frightening moment, April thought Cami was talking to her. The innocent woman was totally swept up in the lurid sexual display. Her cheeks were flushed, and she squeezed her thighs together without even realizing it. She should have given her friend privacy to...do whatever she was doing...but she was rapt by her friend and rooted to the spot. Her lips parted, and she gasped.

“Oh, shit! April!”

Cami turned to her friend, eyes wide with panic. She stopped riding the sex machine, but that only jammed her down onto its shaft. Her mouth dropped open, and her eyes rolled back. She might have wanted to dismount the thing, but dropping her weight onto it triggered a shuddering climax. She tossed her head back, and her voice dropped three octaves.

“Oooooo...fuck...madre dios...oooooo...yeah...”

April thought she might have to catch her friend because the trembling woman looked like she would pass out and slide off the machine. The image of Cami coming would be seared into her brain forever. She didn't know what to do and almost dropped

the casserole dish. Holding such a mundane, domestic item felt absurd. Beneath her deep embarrassment, she realized her pussy was throbbing. April was jealous that the machine made her friend come so hard.

Cami gave a deep sigh and peeled herself off the sex machine. The rumbling machine was much louder when she was off it, and the dildo vibrated so fast that it was a blur. Still, April marveled at its size. She'd be too scared to sit on something that big. Cami was weak-kneed and wobbled before bending down to turn off the machine. She lifted a tiny remote and stopped her camera from recording.

“I'm going to have to shoot that all over again,” she muttered before turning to April. “Sorry you had to walk in on that. This must be quite a shock. Did Viktoria send you back here? I need to have a word with her. She knows I can't be disturbed when I'm working.”

“Am...I...uh...on the video?”

“I don't think so. April, sit down, girl. You look like you're about to faint.”

Cami rushed over and took her friend by the arm, steering her into an office chair that was off to the side. Other than the corner where she was making her video, the rest of the room looked like a standard home office. The chair sat in front of a desk with two gigantic monitors on arms. One of

the screens displayed a gallery of nude photos of Cami. The other was open to a webpage. April was too numb to react to the photos. Her friend still hadn't dressed. She walked around the room in only her bra like it was perfectly normal. Her smooth, swollen pussy drew April's eyes like a magnet.

April didn't feel like she would faint, but her cheeks burned like a hot stovetop. The flush went down her chest. Probably all the way to her toes. She had no context for what she'd just witnessed, and her brain refused to process it. No answer made any sense.

"I really wish you didn't find out this way," Cami said, slipping into a robe that had been hanging on the back of the door, which she closed and made sure to lock. "I should have checked this. I always lock the door, but the girls were running me ragged this morning, and I must have forgotten." She pulled over another chair and sat directly in front of April.

"I...uh...shouldn't have walked in on you. I should have knocked." April wouldn't point out that she tried knocking.

"I can explain. Please try to keep an open mind." She paused. "Do you need a drink or something? Take a deep breath." She leaned forward and had to pull her robe closed before her boobs spilled out.

"I don't need...I'm good. Cami..."

The Latina smiled. "Sorry, everyone around here—on our little cul-de-sac, anyway— knows about this, but I'm sure it's not a thing where you come from. I doubt any of your friends up north did OnlyFans."

"OnlyFans? Is that the thing where women do porn?"

"I prefer to think of myself as a content creator." She grinned.

"OnlyFans is a way for women to take control of their sexuality and directly profit from the content they make. We're in charge."

"So, you..."

"I have a page, and men subscribe—it's almost all men—and they see my pictures and videos, and they can interact with me."

Cami angled the second monitor to face her friend. Her OnlyFans was the page on display. The name displayed was *CalienteQueenVIP*. A column of dirty photos of Cami in lingerie and totally nude ran down the screen. Watching her friend come in person took away the shock of seeing the photos.

"They can get special videos and requests if they want to pay for that."

It's just a business. It isn't any different than women who sell those baskets."

April had many friends who got roped into those MLMs over the years. She used to have all the crap politeness forced her to purchase as proof. The worst part was politely saying no when her friends wanted her to host a party. No, friends trying to recruit her to their team was the worst part. Jeremy would have a fit if she told him she was sucked into a direct marketing scheme. But selling leggings or nail treatments was very different from selling naked pictures of yourself. She stared at her friend and tried to reconcile the sweet woman Cami seemed to be with the kind of woman who'd do that.

"Cami, why?"

"The money, of course. Living down here is so expensive. Marc does very well, but you could always use more, right? Ballet is crazy expensive, and we have to pay Viktoria."

You don't have to have a housekeeper, April thought, instantly regretting it. She didn't want to judge her friend, but she simply couldn't understand.

Cami shyly looked away and added, "And I like it. Modeling for all those men and reading their comments makes me feel sexy. I didn't always look like this, April. I was a chubby girl, and I had terrible skin. My hair was always a mess. I chose to become this version of myself, and after all that hard work, I think I deserve to benefit from it."

"That, I understand. But aren't the guys creepy?"

"Creeps aren't the only ones who look at porn. Do you think Jeremy doesn't? If you do, girl..."

"I'm sure he does. I don't want to know anything about it."

"It's a good idea to know what kind of porn your husband is into. I think a lot of women could learn what their men actually like if they did a little digging."

"I'd never snoop."

"I'm not saying you should spy on your husband. But healthy couples can talk about anything, right?"

April tried to imagine bringing up the topic over Saturday morning coffee. Hey, by the way, what kind of porn do you jerk off to? She nearly

laughed just thinking about it. Although, the conversation may be worth seeing the look on his face.

“What kind of porn does Marc like?”

“He’s into my content, of course. And he really likes cuck stuff.”

Cami read her confusion and explained, “Cucks are guys who get off on the humiliation of their wives fucking other men.”

April laughed, but it was a nervous laugh. “Guys aren’t into that! Men don’t want their wives to sleep with other men. Unless the humiliation is like a BDSM thing, I guess. I don’t know much about that.”

“Oh, girl, I think you need to broaden your horizons, especially down here. If you don’t, you’ll get eaten alive or go running back to New Jersey. I guess you and Jeremy don’t... Haven’t you...”

“Haven’t we what? What are you trying to tell me, Cami?” April was still thrown by the alternate reality she found in her friend’s house, but she was regaining her footing and saw Cami was holding something important back. The woman looked worried, and when she spoke, she dodged the question.

“Men are very into that. Not all of them find it humiliating. Those guys like to see their wives cut loose and get pleasure. It’s very much a thing, and it can be incredible if you’re open to it. Can you imagine Jeremy giving you permission to have whatever hot guy you wanted?”

Visions of Darius Russell swam through her head, and April looked away as if her pretty hazel eyes would give something away. The thought of it was absurd. Darius was hot, but she was a married woman, and decent married women didn’t do that—with or without their husband’s permission. Not that Jeremy would ever give permission for that. I don’t even want permission to sleep with Darius, she thought. April was happy with her husband—even if he had been quick lately.

She dismissed the very idea that Jeremy could ever want her to be with another man out of hand, but that strange bathtub sex they had on their first night in the new house had never left her mind. He accused her of flirting with Chase and seemed very turned on by it. That night had been weird, but it was also the hottest sex they’d had in years. Still, she just couldn’t—wouldn’t—believe he’d ever want her to be with someone else.

“I really can’t imagine Jeremy telling me to have sex with anyone else. I don’t believe Marc would want that either. He might watch those videos, but he’d never let you stroll over to...Chase’s...house, would he?” She paused to intentionally not choose Darius as an example.

“He shares me with all the men on the internet. I don’t hide this from my husband.” April realized that wasn’t an answer. Do they? No, she couldn’t believe it. Making pictures for money was not the same as Cami sleeping with other men. What would Marc do while it happened, sit back and watch? She would not believe it.

“You think I’m some kinky freak, don’t you? It’s written all over your face.”

Cami looked genuinely hurt. April’s heart sank. She truly liked the woman. They were very different—more than she could ever imagine—but Cami was the new friend she related to the most. Is Cami’s sweetness and innocence all a facade? She wouldn’t believe that either.

“I don’t,” April replied, reaching to take her friend’s hand but pausing. She couldn’t help feeling awkward after what she’d witnessed and learned. “It’s a lot to take in, but I don’t think you’re a freak. Like you said, it’s a business. Everyone has a side hustle these days, don’t they?”

“I knew you’d find out eventually, but I hoped we’d know each other better first.” “It’s fine, Cami. Really. I think it’s pretty brave, actually. I’m glad we live in a time when women can control their sexuality. I wish I had your confidence.”

Cami smiled and took her hands. “Oh, you could totally do this, girl. I won’t lie. It’s a lot of work, but you could make serious bank. The guys online would eat a girl like you up.” “Oh god, I couldn’t! First of all, Jeremy is not Marc. He’d never go for it. And second of all, I just couldn’t. I’m not sexy like you. I couldn’t just look right into the camera and do... that. I’ve never done anything that in my life. And what if someone I knew saw it? Aren’t you worried about that?”

“The people who matter most already know. No one from my family or Marc’s will ever see my OnlyFans. I’m not ashamed. If I ever have to explain it, I will. If you’d like, I could put a new attachment on the Sybian, and you could try it. That thing is life-changing, girl.”

“Ohmygod! I couldn’t...no way. I don’t even own a vibrator, Cami! I know that thing would kill me.”

“You don’t own a vibrator? We have got to expand your horizons, April.”

“I’m good. I don’t even really do that.”

“Maybe you are as innocent as you look. That’s sweet, but you’ve entered a different world. You and Jeremy are going to be exposed to a whole different lifestyle. The best advice I can give you is to open your mind and embrace the experience.”

“Okay,” April replied, laughing. “It’s just Miami. We’re not on a different planet. And trust me, I’m not as innocent as you think. Anyway, I just came to drop off your casserole dish. I really should get home.”

“Are we good?”

“We’re good, Cami. You don’t owe me any explanations, but thank you for taking the time.”

The woman pulled April into a tight hug, which felt very strange when Cami was half-naked. She was much too aware of the Latina’s soft curves crushed against her and fought the urge to pull away. She wasn’t as okay with everything as she pretended but hoped she’d get there. All of the other girls on Milford Court were fine with Cami doing porn. April didn’t want to be frozen out for being the uncool one.

Cami saw her to the door, and April very deliberately didn’t run, but walked, across the cul-de-sac to return to the safety of her home.

ten

Jeremy didn't believe everything was okay when April told him she was fine. She'd been acting odd and distracted since returning from the neighbors. She didn't come out and join them in the pool. Instead, she curled up on the couch with her nose buried in her iPad, which wasn't like his wife at all. She loved being active outside and having the family all together.

He stopped asking if she was okay when he realized his concern annoyed her. April was not easily bothered or irritable, which concerned him even more. She was the type to try and put a good face on everything. He hoped she didn't have a falling out with one of her new friends. She needed connections in their new hometown. Jeremy was pleased by how she'd begun to relax when she started hanging out with the other wives on Milford Court. The kids were wiped out from playing in the pool, and after changing out of their wet swimsuits, they flopped down on the couch to watch a movie. He planned to join them there after he changed, but April surprised him in their bedroom. She slipped in while he was pulling off his swim shirt and locked the door behind her.

"Hey, honey, what's up?" he asked.

April kissed him and yanked down his swimming trunks. He kissed her back out of habit before he even realized what was happening. She pumped him, her grasp on his shaft almost too tight. Blood rushed down there so quickly that he became light-headed.

He battled back her tongue while thickening in her hand.

"Ape...what's going..."

"I want you to fuck me, babe." Her lips attacked his again, and she steered him toward the bed.

"What? Right now? The kids..."

“They’re sucked into their movie, and I locked the door. We’ll be fine if we’re quick.” Jeremy tried to pause and think, but his wife was insistent. What the hell is going on? She’s been off all afternoon, and now this? A falling out with her new girlfriends would not explain April jumping him while the kids watched a movie downstairs. But she had his cock throbbing, which made it hard to think.

April crawled onto the bed, offering a nice view of her round ass, before turning to lie down. She stared at him, propped up on her elbows. Her seductive look was out of place on such an adorable face, but it still flared the heat of desire out from his cock and balls. She pulled up her pastel sundress, flashing pale blue panties. He thought he would faint when she stroked fingers over her mound.

“Are you going to fuck me or leave me to take care of this myself?”

The low, sultry voice was not like her at all. Did she get body snatched at the neighbors? He might have laughed at the over-the-top come-on if he weren’t so hard. Being a man finally caught up with his brain, and he realized only an idiot would ignore such an invitation.

Falling on her, Jeremy pulled her panties aside and thrust inside her. Her gasp was followed by a low, satisfied moan. He hadn’t even touched her, but she was slick and ready. Her sheath tightened, pulling him deeper. She planted her feet on the mattress and pressed her hips up at him. Her urgency kicked him into gear.

“Uhhh...god...damn...Ape...”

Jeremy held himself up on his forearms and drove his cock down into his wife. She tightened even more, like she wanted to trap him inside her. Her hips worked at him, and they were out of sync because they were too harried. He slowed down, she sped up, and when they clicked, it was magical. They replaced speed with power. He pounded it into her while April hammered her hips back, a moaning grunt forced from her petite body every time they crashed together.

“Ahhh...yesss...yesss...”

Her legs locked around his waist, and her nails dug into his back. April vibrated with need. He’d never seen her like that, even when she was drunk and horny. If he closed his eyes, he might have thought he was cheating on his wife with a wilder woman—maybe someone like the next-door neighbor, Richelle.

Jeremy couldn't close his eyes because the wildness in her eyes made his blood boil. The gold flecks in her hazel eyes glowed with her passionate intensity. Her desperation brought out the animal in him. He didn't know if he could fuck her any harder, but he tried.

April's moans were rushed. Her mouth hung open, and she licked her dry lips. Her cute tongue peeking out melted his brain. He wasn't going to last. It was impossible.

when she was like that. His entire body burned. Sweat dripped from his forehead, and she blinked it out of her eyes.

"Ape...uhnn...dammit...shit...uhnn...you're...I..."

"Ahhh...not...yet...one...more...god...yesss...YES!"

Jeremy couldn't say her orgasm triggered his because he was already there. She was lucky she came because her *one more minute* was not slowing him down. He tried to pry away from her legs and finish on her stomach, but they were locked. Her thighs only tightened when he tried to escape. With a final, primal grunt, he jacked it deep inside her and filled April with his release. She whined, and her eyes fluttered, and he thought she might have come again when she accepted his seed.

"Ohhh god, baby...yessss..." She clung tightly to him with both arms and legs. He didn't want to crush her, but it felt good to be pressed against her hot little body.

After several minutes of the desperate embrace, April tapped his back and said, "Okay, you need to move now. I'm suffocating."

He reluctantly rolled off his wife and onto his back. Staring at the spinning ceiling fan, he tried to make sense of her behavior. She wasn't totally different since they moved. Most of the time, she was the same woman he'd fallen in love with all those years ago, but she was changing.

Jeremy considered depression, knowing it made people act out in strange ways. She'd left her whole life behind to follow him. But he didn't see how depression would turn her into a naughty sexpot. Peer pressure was another possibility.

These South Florida women were very different from his sweet wife. He saw it every day at the office. Working around so many women flaunting it all the time made his head spin. The other wives on Milford Court could have been pushing April to act like them, but that didn't make sense either. She was one of the most confident, self-assured women he knew.

The other wives in their neighborhood were flashy and seemed to put it all out there. Jeremy liked the idea of April running around in skimpy athleisure wear like they did, but he didn't know if he wanted her to adopt the other wives' forward attitude. He didn't really know them well, but they just radiated it. He didn't want his wife to lose her sweetness.

Beside him, she tugged her panties back into place and smoothed her dress back over her hips before sitting up. She sighed and pushed sweaty hair back from her flushed forehead. She was glowing but not smiling.

"Don't get me wrong, honey. That was amazing, but what got into you?"

April smirked. "You didn't like it?"

"I didn't say that. Maybe I want to know to make sure it gets into you more often."

"Women are allowed to want sex, you know. That's not just a guy thing. Most husbands would be thrilled if their wives pulled them into the bedroom for a mid-afternoon quickie."

"I'm very thrilled. Don't get the wrong idea. We had that burst when we first got here, but we've sort of dropped off since then, so I am thrilled. But come on April, that's not like you. You didn't even let me pull out."

She looked up and did some mental math. "I think we'll be okay. I just wanted you inside me, babe."

"I love just finishing inside you, but again, you're usually so careful. What gives?"

She sighed deeply. "Okay, fine. I saw something over at Cami's. Supposedly, everyone else already knows, but you have to promise you won't say anything. I don't think it's something she goes around bragging about."

Jeremy pushed up from the bed so they were sitting beside each other. "They can't make me testify. Spousal privilege."

"Very funny, counselor. Do you know what OnlyFans is?"

He almost answered, *of course I do*, but he wasn't stupid. "I've heard of it. It's that homemade porn site, isn't it?"

"I'm sure you've *heard of it*." April always saw right through him. Her eyes narrowed. "You'd better not be throwing money away on that. There's plenty of free porn on the internet."

“Hey, who says I watch porn at all? And how do you know about how much free porn is out there?”

“You know me. I watch porn every day when you’re at work and the kids are distracted. I can’t get enough cuckold porn.” She watched him like she was looking for a specific reaction.

“Is this your way of telling me you want to start doing OnlyFans to make some extra money?” he asked, laughing so she’d know he wasn’t serious.

April laughed. “No one would pay to see that.”

“You’re too humble.”

“People will pay to see Cami. They’re not paying to see me.”

“Wait. What? Is Cami doing OnlyFans?”

She was flushed from making love, but her cheeks burned hotter, and she looked away. “I walked in on her making a video.”

“What the... What was she doing?”

“Of course, you want details.” She smacked his arm. “She was by herself. What she was doing doesn’t matter. I walked in on Cami doing... things...and she told me why. She was embarrassed, but not embarrassed if that makes any sense? She’s not ashamed of it, but I think she’s worried I’m upset or offended or something.”

“Are you?”

Jeremy considered that his wife seemed the opposite of upset. Catching Cami in the act—whatever she was doing—obviously got April going.

He would have killed to know what the neighbor was doing when she walked in.

He never considered that his wife was into other women. His mind spiraled into the dirtiest places. She was lucky she didn’t tell him before they had sex, or he never would have lasted long enough for her to get off. *Is there a good way to ask what Cami’s profile name is?* He was not stupid enough to ask that.

“I’m not upset. Or offended. Porn doesn’t offend me. And what Cami does is her business. But I wish it stayed her business. I can’t unsee what I saw. It’s very weird to see someone—especially someone you know—doing *that*. I love Cami. She’s so sweet, but I am worried I won’t be able to look at her without thinking about *that*.”

“Maybe it would help if you told me what *that* was.”

“Seriously, Jeremy?”

He wanted to say, *You’re the one who came in here demanding that I fuck you. How am I out of line? At least you could tell me what got you all horned up!* Instead, he put on a goofy grin and told her, “You’re the fairest, nicest person I know, April. You’ll put this behind you if you want to. Cami is still the same person. You just know something extra spicy about her now.”

“Extra spicy, okay.” She laughed. “I’m sure you’re right. I’m just still all turned around.”

“That’s because of how good I just gave it to you.”

“That must be it.” April kissed him. “Thanks for making me laugh. And the other thing, too. I did get it pretty good. That’s why I love you so much.”

“Any time, honey.”

“I look forward to holding you to that. But I should probably make sure the kids aren’t burning down the house.”

April left, and Jeremy couldn’t get his mind off his sweet, normal wife demanding he *fuck her* because she just witnessed the neighbor doing...*something*. *What did April walk in on?* Cami was by herself, so she was probably masturbating. He imagined the gorgeous Latina on her back with a giant dildo between her legs.

How much did April see? He thought of his wife standing in the doorway and watching, getting hornier as her friend got off. Or perhaps Cami saw her and smiled and intentionally finished while April watched. *Good god, that would be so hot!* he thought. *But what if April didn’t just watch?*

Jeremy stopped before he even started. He would lose it if he thought about his wife going in and taking control of the dildo from her friend. Thinking about April making Cami come would melt his brain. Besides, it was impossible. He’d had some odd, dirty thoughts about his wife lately, but that was beyond the realm of possibility. He didn’t even really think she was into women. Seeing an attractive person performing an intimate act was a turn-on. She didn’t have to be into women to have that reaction.

He went to take a long, hot shower to clear his head. He didn’t need any more wild, dirty thoughts about April in there.

eleven

“Babe, you need to relax. This isn’t just going to your boss’s house. We know these people. They’re our neighbors.”

“I just want to make a good impression. I know Tommy likes me, but I don’t know. Sometimes, it feels like he’s talking down to me. I think this is a good chance to prove that I can fit in. Besides, you’re even tenser than I am. And you’re the one who knows everyone. Well, the wives anyway. I’ve been working so much, I haven’t been around.”

“I’m fine. I just want to fit in, too.”

Jeremy gave April a squeeze. “C’mon. Everyone loves you. That’s how it’s always been, everywhere we go. You’re my ticket to making sure I’m accepted.”

“But everyone down here is so different. I like them all, but I don’t quite feel like I fit in.”

“They’re always texting you to hang out. They’ve accepted you. You’re worried about nothing.”

“We’ll see. Besides, I haven’t seen Cami since I walked in on her. I’ve been purposely avoiding her.”

“Well, today, you rip the band-aid off. Just, I don’t know, if you look at her and that flashes into your mind, force yourself to think about something else—like baseball.”

“Haha. Very funny. I think I’d feel better if the kids were with us. Adult parties are fun, but I’ll be worried about them the whole time we’re at this thing.”

They’d dropped the kids off at Richelle and Chase’s. All the neighborhood kids were gathered there for a party of their own, supervised by Izzy, the McLaughlin’s nanny, and Viktoria, the Goldmans’ housekeeper-slash-nanny. Jeremy thought it was odd that the kids wouldn’t be with them. Fourth of July barbecues felt like family events, but apparently, this was the Siegels’ tradition, and he wasn’t going to buck that.

He tried to guess what to expect. They didn’t run in such swanky circles in their old life in New Jersey. The affair could be anything from a fully catered soiree to the man himself, Tommy Siegel, manning a six-thousand-dollar grill and doling out Cuban cigars while the wives gathered on the other side of the pool to do whatever the wives did down there in South Florida. He didn’t think they swapped crochet patterns and baking tips like back in Hamilton.

A beautiful, blonde Irish girl in her twenties answered the Siegels’ door. Jeremy knew he could easily get lost in her brilliant sapphire eyes. They were so distracting that it took him a moment to realize the girl’s big, natural breasts stretched a green tank top that seemed a size too small. April knew the girl was Nora, the Siegels’ au pair, and said hello. He wasn’t surprised Tommy’s live-in help looked like that but wondered how Mrs. Siegel felt about having a girl like Nora under her roof.

Nora showed them through the huge house to the rear. Jeremy couldn’t believe their homes were only a few doors apart on the same cul-de-sac. They had a nice house, but the Siegels lived in a mansion. The backyard was just as opulent. While their pool consumed most of the Sampsons’ backyard, a large pool was just a part of the expansive space.

An elaborate waterfall fed the pool, making it seem more secret grotto than backyard pool. A large, in-ground hot tub was connected but walled off from the pool. A twisting slide was the only thing about the pool that suggested children lived at the house, and it wasn’t just an adults’ play area. Chase was rocketing down the slide and splashed into the pool as the Sampsons entered.

The beautiful patio included both a shaded seating area with outdoor furniture that looked nicer than the stuff the Sampsons had had back home

and a large table to the left. The expected mammoth grill was there, not far from an outdoor wet bar. A massive flatscreen was mounted on the back of the house. Of course, Tommy Siegel had to watch his clients while relaxing at home.

“Hey, guys, I’m thrilled you’re here,” Richelle said, coming to greet them. She hugged April first, with an added kiss on the cheek.

“We wouldn’t miss it. Besides, aren’t we supposed to be the guests of honor?” April replied.

“You are. Great to see you again, Jeremy. We’ve got to get to know each other better.” Richelle hugged him, too, and he prayed that he wouldn’t pop an immediate boner. She was spilling out of a black bikini top with a white sarong tied across her hips. The cheek kiss made him unreasonably hot, and he felt like a rube. This wasn’t how Miami people behaved.

“I can try to have a word with Tommy, but he doesn’t listen to me. You know that. I’m so thrilled to meet you both.”

“Oh, you guys haven’t met Marti yet. This is our wonderful hostess,” Richelle said.

Jeremy didn’t need an introduction. He’d been watching her on the local news since they moved there because he wanted to know what kind of a woman was a match for a guy like Tommy.

Marti Siegel was even more impressive in person. She was sweet and funny on the air—and authoritative when she needed to be. The anchorwoman was also beautiful, which was part of the job, whether anyone wanted to admit it or not. The only surprise was that she was even more stunning in person. She was nearly as tall as Jeremy in cork wedge sandals, with perfect blonde hair and curves that looked like they were engineered to test every male she met. Her tits definitely looked engineered. He knew she had to be in her fifties, but couldn’t believe it.

Marti wore tight but respectable dresses on the air. By her own pool, she shed that image in a barely-there red, white, and blue string bikini that wasn’t at all hidden by a white mesh coverup. Jeremy realized he was staring and quickly looked away, but her smile told him he’d been caught. He just hoped his wife didn’t notice.

“I’ve heard so much about you that I feel like I already know you,” April gushed.

“Wow, you’re just as sweet as everyone says. That’s a refreshing change around here. I’m so happy to welcome you and Jeremy to our home. I’m sorry if Tommy’s been bury- ing your husband in work. The men at Stirling never stop.”

“It’s okay. I’m just thrilled to be somewhere so dynamic,” Jeremy said.

“Don’t let my husband hear you say that. He’ll cut your pay if he thinks he can get away with it. But he must be impressed with you if he wants you to be an employee and our neighbor. I look forward to getting to know you better, too. Perhaps Richelle and I should tag team you for lunch sometime. I think we’re all going to become quite close. I know that’s what Tommy wants, too.”

“And Tommy always gets what Tommy wants,” Richelle added.

Jeremy couldn’t follow the conversation. His brain locked up when Marti suggested *Richelle and I should tag team you*. He took it the dirtiest possible way. Any man would when confronted with those two women.

“You guys make him sound like a king,” April replied with a nervous laugh.

“Sometimes, I think he believes he is,” Marti said.

“Which makes you the queen,” Richelle said.

“Oh, stop it, Shelly. No one is as regal as you. Now, Jeremy, we’re going to steal your sweet wife and get her a drink. Why don’t you go and find the boys? Ask Tommy about his grill. He loves talking about that thing.” Marti’s tone was a verbal eyeroll.

The women each took one of April’s arms and led her off, leaving Jeremy to fend for himself. At least, she looked as lost as he felt. Marti Siegel was just as much of a force of nature as her husband. King and Queen was an apt way to describe the couple. He questioned if he and April were cut out to be subjects.

Jeremy was at a loss without his wife’s safety net. Because he’d been working so much, Tommy was the only one he knew at the barbecue. He didn’t want to make a

beeline for his boss and seem like a stuck-up, so he went to a cooler he spotted, grabbed a cold beer, and took a moment to absorb the scene.

Chase splashed around in the pool with a blonde who looked too young to be married to anyone at the barbecue. Jeremy knew she had to be Peyton, who was married to the large Black guy he saw on their first day

on Milford Court, Darius Russell. She warned Chase when he nearly wet her hair.

The Russells were separated by over twenty years, and she had trophy wife written all over her, so he made the obvious assumption. Jeremy didn't judge—or he tried not to. He couldn't blame Darius for falling for a literal cheerleader. He'd learned his neighbor looked so familiar because he was a retired football player. Darius also happened to be a Stirling client. Peyton was a cheerleader for his old team, and they met at a charity event—ending his first marriage.

The backyard had the space for a large gathering, but Jeremy only saw neighbors. Cami wasn't around, and he wondered if she was inside with her husband. The only thing he knew about Marc Goldman was that he was also a lawyer. A familiar lump of a man came out of the house and settled into the seating area, scowling at his phone. It was Sammy, the fixer from Stirling. Of all the people Tommy could have invited from work, that was a surprise. He didn't want to be drawn into a conversation with the brute and turned away before Sammy could spot him, nearly running into the wall that was Darius.

“Hey, man, how's it hanging? You're Jeremy, right?”

“Yeah, that's me. I'm good. Just working hard.”

“I'm glad Tommy keeps you on your toes over there. My career is in your hands.”

“Aren't you switching networks in the fall?”

“For sure. You guys got me a sweet deal to go over to streaming. They want names so they seem legit, and who's more legit than Darius Russell? Am I right?”

“Yeah, totally. I guess that means you're on the road a lot in the fall.”

“I'll fly out on Tuesday afternoons and fly home on Fridays. It's a much better deal because I won't be away every weekend anymore.”

“Must be hard on the family, I guess.”

“Playing was harder because I was always at the practice facility in season. But that's one of the reasons I value living here on Milford Court. I like knowing the rest of you are here to look after Peyton and take care of her when I can't be around. And I want you to know that I've got sweet April covered while you're working, my man. Rest assured, I've got my eye on her.”

The lurid way Darius said it raised his hackles. Jeremy wanted to believe he was mis-reading the man, but men openly flirting with and leering at women seemed to be a Miami thing. The way the big man talked about April was just an extension of that. All of the women at Stirling seemed to accept it as part of the job. He felt like he'd stepped onto the set of *Mad Men*, except the women wore way less.

"I know I'm a lucky man," he defensively replied, not understanding why he felt the need.

"We all are. Listen, I played pro ball for twelve years. I've never had an issue with the ladies, but having a girl like Peyton at my age is a treat. Getting a girl like April would be a special treat. I bet she's got hidden fire, doesn't she?"

"Yeah, sure. I guess so. She's a great wife."

"Oh yeah, she is. A lot of great, fun wives here on Milford Court."

Darius slapped him on the back so hard that he nearly dropped his beer. Jeremy felt like he was already drunk because it seemed like he and the football player were having two different conversations. The man's subtext was clear. *Am I supposed to say something about how hot Peyton is?* He could think of all sorts of things to say about the blonde cheerleader, but he wasn't raised to tell other guys how hot their wives are.

"What are you guys conspiring about over there? You're not intimidating my boy Jeremy, are you?" Tommy called out from the grill. He'd just carried back plates stacked with various meats.

Darius walked over, and Jeremy followed. "Nah, we were just talking wives, and I was telling him how great it is to be in a tight group like we have here on Milford Court. We take care of each other here."

"He's got that right, champ. And no one takes care of the wives like Darius does. Right, brother?"

"I just take care of business. Y'know know what I'm sayin'?"

"Oh, I know," their host replied, heartily laughing. "I'm lucky I'm not an insecure man."

"I don't know anyone who's more of a swinging dick player than you, my man."

The men exchanged a complex handshake, and Jeremy felt like he was on the outside looking in. He wasn't a wallflower, but he never had the swagger of these men, and he couldn't match it now—especially not when

he was trying to decode all the talk about wives. It had to be some weird hazing thing because it couldn't be what he thought they were implying.

"How about you, big dog?" Darius asked. "Do you take care of business?"

Jeremy needed a moment to realize he was *Big Dog*. *Why do all of their nicknames sound demeaning?* "Uh, yeah, I take care of business."

"I hope so, champ. I set our boy here up with one of our best assistants, Liliana. You know her, right Darius?"

"Yeah, I do. Nice score, big dog."

"Just don't let her get the upper hand, or she'll eat you alive."

"She's great, Mr.—I mean, Tommy. Yeah, Liliana is great. But, you know, I'd never do anything inappropriate in your office. Or anywhere else. I love April."

The other men shared a look before bursting out laughing. "I don't think anything is inappropriate in Tommy's office," Darius said.

"I get what you're saying, champ. I appreciate a loyal man. I'm glad you wouldn't sneak around behind your wife's back. That shows character. But you're in a different world now. You and April both. And we all love April, too. A woman like her inspires loyalty."

"But we only get one life, champ. I'd suggest the two of you embrace that and seize every opportunity you have. Don't let someone else's uptight ideas hold you back."

"Yeah, fuck that," Darius agreed.

"Sure, Tommy," Jeremy replied uncertainly. "This is a new start for us. We plan to make the most of it."

"That's good to hear, champ. Good to hear. Now, how do you like your steak?" He tossed thick slabs of beef onto the grill. The sizzle filled his ears.

"Medium?"

"Are you asking me or telling me? You need to be assertive."

Darius locked an iron grip on his shoulder. "Yeah, big dog. The ladies around here like a real man. Show them that you are one, and the world is yours. You don't want them to think you're some kind of cuck boy."

"Definitely don't want that," Tommy laughed.

Jeremy got the sinking feeling that none of this was about hazing the new kid on the block. This new world was alien, but he could read between

the lines. These men were talking about a swinging, wife-swapping thing. He wanted to believe they meant something else because the idea that he'd moved his family down into a swinging community was horrifying.

The thought that either Tommy or Darius would allow another man to touch their wives was absurd. He knew what a cuck was, and neither man was a cuck. They were far too manly. He was sure they were cheaters—alphas often were—but that didn't mean they afforded their wives the same flexibility. He had to be wrong. The men had to be engaging fucking around to see if he was gullible enough to hit on one of the Milford Court wives. Jeremy wouldn't take that bait. But he would play along so they didn't think he was weak or naive.

"They don't need to worry about that. There are no cuck boys here. Am I right, guys?" He plastered on a smile and hoped it hid his rising panic. The expensive steaks smelled amazing, but he'd never be able to eat with his stomach so tied in knots.

twelve

April sipped from the giant glass of sangria Marti poured her. She tried to be careful and go slowly rather than give in to her nerves and down the fishbowl of booze. She had to be extra careful because of the bright sun beating down on them. Getting drunk at Jeremy's boss's house would be an embarrassment.

They sat with their legs dangling in the cool, refreshing pool. She felt boyish sitting between the other two women. Richelle may as well have been sitting there naked for how much of her flawless body that string bikini covered. April smiled, thinking how Jeremy's eyes popped out of his head when he saw her friend. He was just a man, so she didn't blame him, but he'd hear about it later. Her earnest husband was too easy to tease. She was sure he would have stared at Marti in the same way if she weren't his boss's wife.

Marti Siegel was built like a stripper. She didn't think of it as mean because it was a compliment in her eyes. The mature woman had the kind of curves that had launched a thousand Stifler's Mom fantasies, and her mesh cover-up didn't actually cover anything. She saw the gleam of Marti's navel piercing through it.

April didn't even judge the giant implants. Not every woman could be blessed by God with a body like Richelle's—or Cami's. She envied the confidence to get the fake boobs. Her cute handfals fit her body well, but part of her always wished she had a body that stopped traffic like Marti's. But she'd never have the confidence to just show up one day with double-Ds and dare anyone to comment.

Having all the attention focused on her was flattering, but it made her uncomfortable because she hadn't been around people so interested in her for such a long time. She could see why Marti was so good at her job. The woman made April feel like she was the most interesting woman in the world. Their hostess was just as fascinated by April's pageant past as the other women on Milford Court. She hadn't talked about her competition days so much in years. The blonde anchor lauded her confidence to get up

on a stage in a bikini—that was back when swimsuits were still part of it—but she knew the woman would have strutted out there with far more swagger than April ever had.

She was pretty, smart, and talented, but some of the other girls she competed against made her feel like an impostor. It was like how she felt sitting there with Marti and Richelle in their bikinis. Either of her new friends would have gone much further than she had in the pageant world. April was sure of that.

Oddly, she felt that old competitive drive kick in around the other wives at the pool. She wanted one of the other husbands to trip over their tongue like Jeremy did when he saw Richelle.

“I’m sure you miss the attention,” Marti said, sipping her drink. She’d finished her champagne and switched to sangria, as did Richelle.

“What do you mean?” April asked.

“A girl doesn’t go into pageants or anything else like that unless she likes attention. There’s no shame in it. I wouldn’t be on TV if I didn’t like attention on some level.”

“I don’t think that’s why I did it. It was like cheerleading. I liked the challenge and the performance aspect. I didn’t mind the attention. I never did, but I don’t feel like that’s why I did it.”

Richelle smiled. “A pageant queen *and* a cheerleader? Don’t try to tell me you don’t like attention.”

“And a specific kind of attention. It’s not like you ran for class president. You wanted to be noticed for being pretty,” Marti added.

“That’s not true. God, that sounds so shallow!” April protested.

“It is not shallow. Don’t most of us want to be beautiful and have people know it? I don’t think that’s shallow at all, and if it is, I don’t care,” Richelle said.

“Says one of the most beautiful people I’ve ever seen,” April replied. She wouldn’t have admitted that if she weren’t on the defense.

“Aww, that’s so sweet. Thanks, April.” Richelle put an arm around her and squeezed her tight.

“I know not all of us are the same. A lot of women reject it, but some of us want men to notice us. Obviously, I mean *the right* men, like our husbands, but my point is that we want to be desired. I’m sure you miss that from your days as a cheerleader and beauty queen. Don’t even try to tell me that having boys chase you didn’t feel good,” Marti said.

April allowed a smile. “Sure, flirting with boys was always fun. Especially when I was younger. You need all the positive affirmation you can get at that age.”

“At this age, too.” Marti laughed.

“Right?” Richelle agreed. “I don’t think I’ll ever *not* want that kind of affirmation. I take care of myself because I want to be healthy and feel good, but don’t be fooled, honey. I don’t do all this for myself.” She gestured at her body with her free hand. They were sitting by the pool at a backyard barbecue, but the woman looked like she could step right onto a runway. “I’d be crushed if the guys here didn’t notice.”

“They always notice you, Shelly,” Marti affirmed. “They want you.”

“I don’t see anything wrong with that. Who doesn’t want men chasing after them? They might even catch me if they’re lucky.”

April wanted to tell her friend that Jeremy certainly noticed her but felt that outing him would be wrong—especially after Marti’s comment. She didn’t want to tell Richelle that Jeremy *wanted* her. She wasn’t naive, but she didn’t want to believe that her husband wanted other women in a real way. April had complete trust in him.

The other women didn’t appear to have any reservations about their husbands wanting the other wives on Milford Court. She didn’t mind Jeremy harboring a puppy dog crush, but Marti seemed to be talking about something more serious. Tommy struck April as the kind of man who’d sleep with Richelle if he had the chance. *Would Marti be okay with that?* she wondered. Their hostess was so causal about it that she thought just Marti just might be fine with it.

She remembered what Cami said about men who liked their wives being with other women. Was there an equivalent for women? She could never. There was no way April could sit back and watch Jeremy do it with someone else right in front of her.

April didn’t even want him to flirt with other women. An unspoken crush was one thing. Openly flirting was disrespectful. She still carried residual guilt for the way she acted with Chase that day.

But no, Richelle wasn’t talking about flirting. April didn’t want to believe it, but the gorgeous Asian woman implied she wanted the other husbands to want to screw her. April would never want that from a friend’s husband. It was so inappropriate. She did not see Chase’s flirting that way.

Her mind went right back to Darius. She even looked over to where he was chatting with Jeremy and Tommy. Her tummy fluttered before a pit of guilt formed. She was sure he wanted her that evening they met outside. And she liked it.

April liked it in a way that made her pussy tingle. She tried not to blame herself because Darius probably did that to every woman, but that didn't make it right to lust over another man like that. She couldn't truly be sure that she'd have pushed him away if he'd kissed her.

The contrast between Darius and her husband was striking when she saw them beside each other. Jeremy was a handsome man. Her lust for the neighbor had nothing to do with lacking desire for her husband. But Darius was not like other men.

Her husband was six feet tall, but the former football player still had nearly half a foot on him. And while Jeremy was fit for a normal guy, Darius was an ebony god. With his long, powerful limbs and sculpted abs, he looked like he could step right back on the field, even though he had to be over fifty. His giant hands alone gave April the dirtiest thoughts. She didn't know if she could even be around the man when he was wearing nothing but tight swimming trunks.

"Did we lose you?" Richelle asked, snapping her out of the trance. She followed April's gaze and knowingly smiled. "Which one? I mean, Darius is obvious. We all wanted him the moment we laid eyes on him. But god, Tommy is sexy. He just has that thing that some men have."

April drank and tried to recover. "How do you know I wasn't looking at my husband?"

Marti laughed. "Women don't look at their husbands that way. Don't get me wrong, Tommy is still the only man who can tame me, but I don't usually look at him the way you're looking over there, sweetie. Don't be shy. We share everything here. I don't mind if you look at my husband that way. I get it more than anyone. I married him."

"Reeling in a man like Tommy might be your most impressive accomplishment," Richelle said.

"Not being the mother to four kids or building a two-decade career in broadcast journalism?" She sipped her sangria and shrugged. "In this context, you may be right. Tommy Siegel is not the settling down type."

"Then it's a good thing he found you."

The other women raised their glasses to toast, and April joined in, but she was trying to wrangle the wild thoughts ricocheting around her head. She'd been put off by Tommy's aggression and forwardness in their initial meetings, but now she saw what her friends meant about him. He was just as powerful as Darius in his own way, and that was sexy. Ordinary men didn't carry themselves the way Tommy did.

He also had a kind of brutish appeal she hadn't considered before. He was only about her height—average for a woman, short for a man—but he had arms like telephone poles and a chest that looked like it had been chiseled from granite, shown off by a black tank top. Both arms bore tattoos. Tommy was bluntly handsome, which was not ordinarily her thing, but it worked for him.

April didn't look at older men that way—he was nearly old enough to be her father—but the other women were right. Tommy had a certain something that made her tingle. She blamed them for making her see it. Being around such open, lusty women was exposing sides of April she didn't even know existed.

"Yeah, she gets it," Richelle said, nodding.

"I don't get anything," she protested, hitting her sangria again. It was becoming a crutch.

"You will, sweetie," Marti said. "I hope you're okay with us being such a bawdy group. I don't make any apologies for it. We're all grown men and women and don't see the point of keeping up pretenses or denying our desires."

"Life is too short to play games," Richelle agreed.

April thought she'd already had too much sangria in the sun because she had the unsettling feeling that the other wives were talking about much more than sharing dirty thoughts about each other's husbands, and that couldn't be true. Marti couldn't possibly be implying that April could have Tommy if she wanted him.

April excused herself to use the bathroom. She needed a moment away from the women to breathe and think. On her way into the house, she stopped and refilled her sangria glass, even though the sweet cocktail had already started buzzing her brain.

She threw off her cover-up before entering the house and regretted it. The blast of cold air conditioning was refreshing, but it chilled her. She

wasn't as exposed as the other women, but the sudden temperature drop raised goosebumps everywhere.

After throwing water on her face, she stared into the bathroom mirror. She hadn't compared herself to other women since her pageant days, but now, twenty years later, April looked at herself in the mirror and questioned if she measured up. The other wives were in her head. She did not chase men's attention, but being around women like Richelle and Marti made her want to be noticed.

Her hair was up in a high ponytail, and she considered putting it down but knew it wouldn't look right unless she brushed it out or ran to the pool and jumped right in to slick it back. Marti's blonde hair was perfectly coiffed, and Richelle's waves of luscious raven locks had perfect bounce. April feared her chestnut hair was mousy next to the others.

She'd put on minimal makeup, just enough so she didn't look too pale next to the other tanned women of Milford Court, but now she wished she'd done more. Richelle always looked perfect in a way that somehow seemed like she'd made no effort at all. At least, the sangria stained her full lips red. She sipped more of it. *I have to get this recipe*, she mused.

April posed in the mirror and wondered if she could get away with a tiny bikini like the other wives. Marti had to be almost twenty years older than her, and she did it. That non-covering cover-up had to be coming off at some point, and she knew the husbands would be drooling over their hostess—Jeremy included. *Would he want a woman that much older? I don't see it*, she convinced herself. She'd only seen Peyton splashing around in the pool with Chase but knew the ex-cheerleader was just as exposed as the other wives.

She still had two-piece swimsuits, but nothing like the others'. She hadn't worn one to the barbecue. Her navy tank suit with the white piping was cute and sporty, with a zipper down the front and a racerback. She wanted to be appropriate for a barbecue at Jeremy's boss's house but was coming to understand that *appropriate* meant something very different on Milford Court. She feared just how different it was for these couples.

April sucked in her tummy—not that she had much of one—and stuck out her butt—she had too much of that—and thought that maybe she could pull off a string bikini. *Well, maybe if I pose like this the whole time*. She'd never even tried to wear anything as tiny as Richelle, even before two kids,

when she might have been able to pull it off. She tried plumping her chest with both hands and laughed. *Maybe if I filled out a bikini like Richelle. Or I could get the number of Marti's surgeon.*

The break was what she needed, and April left the bathroom ready to strut out to the pool with her head held high—and ran straight into Cami and Marc.

“Oh, hey. I’m so glad to see you. I guess you’ve still been busy getting settled,” Cami said.

April laughed nervously. “I don’t think I’ll ever be done.” She’d been avoiding Cami—and the other wives—since her revelation, and running into the woman felt as awkward as she feared.

“Marc, this is April. Her family moved into the Martellis’ house.”

“Oh, right. Hi, April. Where are you guys from?”

“Central Jersey,” she replied, taking his offered hand.

“Wow, this must be quite a change for you guys then. The culture shock must be dis-orienting.” He had a pleasant smile.

She felt like he meant Milford Court and not Miami in general. Marc was a pleasant surprise because he was the first normal person she’d met there. He wasn’t a stud like the other men in their cul-de-sac, but just an ordinary middle-aged guy. Marc was the only person there who would have fit in back in her old neighborhood. *How did he end up with someone like Cami?* she wondered. *He’s so...normal.*

April had to remind herself that Marc Goldman wasn’t what he seemed. She knew things about him she wished she didn’t. Things she didn’t want to know about anyone. He liked cuckold porn, according to his wife. Of course, she’d searched for what that was while trying very hard to avoid actually seeing any. *He doesn’t seem like he’d jerk off to videos of married women screwing other men.*

Nor did Marc seem like the kind of man who’d let his wife do internet porn, but the two were probably linked together. She realized Cami wasn’t the sort of woman who allowed a man to *let* her do anything. April wasn’t either, but she knew Jeremy would have something to say if she wanted to start an OnlyFans account.

He just seems so normal. She couldn’t stop thinking it. *How is he okay with that? Or does Cami wear the pants, and it doesn’t matter what*

he thinks? She wouldn't want to be in that kind of a marriage either. She treasured that she and Jeremy were equals.

"It's been an adjustment," she finally answered, hoping her musings weren't written all over her face. She hated that everyone read her so easily.

"I'm sure you and your husband will get along fine here." He didn't sound like he meant it. "You wouldn't have moved here if you weren't Milford Court people."

"I guess we'll see," she replied, nervously laughing.

"I've always thought you should try something before you decide it's not for you," Cami said. "How do you know if you don't try it?"

"There are just some things I know aren't for me," April replied.

"Marc, honey, why don't you take our stuff outside? We'll catch right up, but I need to ask April about something while I've got her alone."

His eyes darted between the women, and April realized he must know that she knew. Her cheeks flushed.

"Sure, hon. Just don't take too long. You know I hate going to these things without you." Marc looked like he truly dreaded going out to the barbecue.

Cami took April's hand and led her over to sit on the couch. She stared like she was trying to figure out how to start. Meanwhile, April was distracted trying to figure out her bikini. Strings went everywhere like putting on the swimsuit was solving a puzzle, but somehow, it covered even less than the other wives' bikinis. A gold chain around her belly complicated things further.

"Come out and say it if you think I'm gross."

"Wow, that's direct," April said. "I do not think you're gross. Or a slut. Or immoral."

"I didn't even suggest any of those things. Thanks." Cami laughed.

"Sorry, I wasn't implying I ever thought any of those things. I guess I do feel weird, but honestly, it's about me, not you. I don't think I'm sheltered, but I've led a very conventional life. Jeremy and I are about as normal as you can get. We're boring, even."

"So, I'm not normal?" Cami held a serious, offended look before breaking into a smile. "I'm messing with you. I hear what you're saying. Just learning about something like that would be shocking enough, but unfortunately, you walked in on it."

“I sure did. I was not prepared for that.”

“God, I hope it wasn’t too gross. That wasn’t meant for your eyes.”

“No, not gross.”

Why did I say it like that? But April knew exactly why that slipped out of her mouth. She hadn’t been able to stop thinking about what she’d seen, and none of those thoughts were disgust. A vivid memory of Cami’s climax flashed into her mind. *Oooooo... fuck...madre dios...oooooo... yeah...* April pushed it away.

She was fascinated by all of it. The confidence and bravery Cami had to put herself

out on the internet like that stunned her. April could never do that for so many reasons, but part of her wished was the type of woman who could, if she chose to. And then there was the act itself. She’d been all over Jeremy since she walked in on Cami. Whenever she closed her eyes at night, it came rushing back to her, bringing with it a visceral thrill.

Riding that machine was another thing she was sure she could never do, but her friend came so hard on it. April was dying to know what it felt like to ride that scary sex machine. She focused on that part of it because she didn’t want to analyze being aroused by her sexy friend’s orgasm.

“Not gross.” Cami smiled. “Which part of it do you like the best? Is it the showing off? Are you curious about the Sybian?”

“Why do you all think I want to be seen like that? Sorry, I didn’t mean to snap. Shelly and Marti were going on about the same thing out at the pool.”

Cami touched her arm, bringing an unexpected tingle. April fought the urge to pull away. She didn’t like that she liked the touch. “We all want to be seen like that. Some part of us does, anyway. Don’t you want to be desired?”

“Of course. But that—and this is no judgment—that’s for my husband. I shouldn’t be putting that out there for other men. Forget how it would make Jeremy feel. It would make me an awful tease.”

“Only if you’re just teasing.”

“What are you... Cami, I’m not a cheater.”

There it was again, the implication that she, a married woman, could just have other men. She couldn’t consider it.

“I wasn’t talking about cheating, April.” She took both the innocent wife’s hands. “You’ve entered a very different world down here.”

“People keep saying that.” The temptation of Darius Russell was stark in her mind, but she would never give in to it.

“It’s true. I’m not saying you should or shouldn’t do anything. Only you know what’s right for you. Don’t ever let someone push you into anything. But try to keep an open mind. An opportunity may present itself, and you could miss out if you can’t expand your horizons.”

“That sounds like what they say in improv. Yes and... everything. I don’t know if my horizons could ever expand that far. I think I know what you mean, and I just wasn’t raised that way.”

“Do you think I was?” Cami laughed. “My parents are old-school Catholics from Cuba. They used to take Communion in secret before they fled for America. But I’m not bound by their values. I want an exciting life. I want to take a big bite of that apple.”

Well, she’s confirmed it without confirming it. I guess she and Marc are one of those cuckold couples. And everyone else is okay with it. Things really are different down here.

“But I don’t know if I’d want anything like that. And it’s not because of my parents.”

“We don’t know what we want and what we’ve been programmed to want until we really sit down and think about it. That’s all I’m saying, April. If you and Jeremy are into something, why isn’t that a good enough reason to do it?”

She felt like Cami was trying to twist her head around. She’d never said that she and Jeremy were into anything. *How would I even know if he’d want...that? I could never ask him that! I don’t even want to ask him that! Why am I even thinking about this? It’s not us, and it’s not going to happen.*

“I’ll take your word for it. But I think I just might be boring after all, Cami.”

Thirteen

Jeremy was happy to separate from the other guys when he needed a fresh beer. He liked to think he was a guy’s guy who could hang with anyone, but Darius and Tommy were just too hardcore for him. He couldn’t see chasing women—especially married women—as sport.

Not only would he never cheat on April, but if in some crazy scenario where the opportunity arose, he wouldn't help a married woman cheat on her husband either. He had to believe that marriage meant something. The ring on his finger wasn't just jewelry. He knew his wife took that as seriously as he did.

April came out of the house with Cami while he was opening his fresh beer. He gaped at the stunning woman, and his mind went right back to imagining what she was doing when April walked in on her. The sexy Latina was built for sex, so it wasn't hard to go there, even without his secret knowledge. He'd love to know Cami's OnlyFans name, but he wasn't brave enough to ask his wife.

His mind didn't stick to what Cami was doing on her own. It roped April into the dirty fantasy like it always did. Reality didn't matter. Thinking about his sweet wife being so overcome with lust that she joined her friend was too easy. He would have been ashamed of himself if it didn't make him so hard. He had to go sit on one of the chaise lounges by the pool before anyone noticed. *Maybe I'm not as different from the other guys here as I'd like to think.*

April broke away from Cami and came to him rather than return to the other wives. "You put on sunscreen, right?" she asked, eyeing him suspiciously.

"Of course I did. This sun is brutal. I'm surprised you're out in it at all."

"I'd put on my big, floppy hat, but I don't want to be that girl. Not in this crowd."

"Honey, you're the prettiest girl here, floppy hat or not."

She looked around the pool and clearly wasn't buying it. All of the wives on Milford Court were insanely hot, but April was still the one for him. He may have plenty of dirty thoughts along the way, but she was the one he'd always go home with.

"I have eyes," she replied, laughing. She dropped onto his lap, and he jumped. The reason why was evident, and she wiggled her cute, round ass against it. "I suppose you want me to believe that's all for me."

"It always is."

"Babe, I wasn't even out here. You're lucky I'm not the jealous type."

Jeremy was glad she was smiling. She really never exhibited jealousy. Sometimes, he wished she would just to prove she still thought he could get it. April was the opposite of jealous. She put an arm around him and planted a deep kiss. He was so startled that he almost didn't kiss her back. She didn't mind PDA, but she didn't kiss him like that in front of other people. He held the small of her back and wondered if he'd get away with grabbing her ass.

"I guess I know it's for me now," she said, peeling back and smiling. She had to feel him throbbing against her.

"How many of those glasses of wine have you had?"

He wasn't complaining, but this wasn't like her. Her cheeks were rosy, too, and he knew it wasn't the heat. Her nipples were sharp points in her swimsuit, and he hoped it was for him and not from being in the air-conditioned house.

"Are you monitoring my drinking, *Dad*? Do I need to be drunk to want to kiss my husband?"

"Just asking. And hey, you can kiss me like that anytime you like."

Jeremy pulled her into another kiss. She resisted at first but really wanted to kiss him and melted under his persistence. His hand drifted to her ass that time, and she didn't move it. Her nails dug into his scalp. *I wish I knew how much she liked making out in public years ago*, he thought. He kissed his wife like he had a point to prove. Maybe he did after that weird conversation with Tommy and Darius.

April only let him kiss her for a moment or two. She was left breathless, but she still pulled away. "I don't think so, buster. You don't want my drunken kisses. I guess I'll have to go find someone who does."

He knew she was joking, but she'd have plenty of takers with the men of Milford Court around. *I hope she doesn't figure that out*. That was an odd thought. His wife wasn't looking to make out with other men. *She'd better not be*. But there was Chase McLaughlin, watching them from the pool. He'd been occupied with Peyton Russell, but she moved down to join the other wives and greet Cami. April seemed like she might be open to making out with Chase the day they moved into their new house. *Don't be an asshole and . . .* let those guys get into your head, he chided himself, but he went there anyway.

“Your new pal Chase is right there. I bet he likes you in a swimsuit.” Jeremy had no idea why the words came out, but his cock strained against her ass when they did.

April had the strangest look, like she’d had an epiphany. And then she looked confused. Finally, she replied, “I think I’ll go find out. I could use a dip in the pool anyway. It’s blazing out here. Now you can gawk at the other wives in peace.”

“Honey, what? Wait.”

He swore she put an extra swish in her hips when she slipped off his lap and strutted to the pool. Jeremy wasn’t the only one who noticed. Their conversation must have made him paranoid because he swore they watched his wife like a pride of lions sizing up its prey. She waded into the pool and straight to where Chase lurked low in the water. He swore the man smirked at him.

Jeremy put his annoyance aside and basked in the pride of the other husbands lust-ing after his wife. The women of Milford Court were all extraordinary, and he was thrilled April held her own with them. More than held her own, he’d say.

The other wives were all practically naked—even Tommy’s wife, who’d thrown off that mesh thing to reveal a scrap of an American flag that had been fashioned into a bikini. Her body was ridiculous for any age, but especially her age. He couldn’t recall ever finding a woman with a decade on him so attractive.

Marti seemed to be begging for attention like all the wives, but April drew all the husbands without flaunting it. She earned their lust in a conventional one-piece tank suit.

Jeremy realized he wouldn’t mind if she flaunted it like the other wives. He’d never had that kind of thought about his wife. The men had planted ideas in his head, but that one was unexpected.

He looked at the other wives, hoping his sunglasses made it less obvious, and tried to picture April in their bikinis. She loved her country. She wouldn’t fill out that flag bikini like Marti, but she’d look amazing in it. April would still be falling out of it if the cups were as tiny as the one Marti wore. He thought he’d pounce if she ever wore a belly chain like Cami and Peyton. Peyton’s tight, young ass was more exposed than covered in her bikini. April’s ass was rounder, but that would only make her look hotter in that bikini.

The other husbands were staring when April was in her one-piece. What would they do if she strutted it around like their wives? They may have been into her precisely because she was so different, but Jeremy didn't think so. They'd be all over her if she were dressed like Cami. And if she were, they'd see everything. He was sure the Latina's white bikini would turn see-through if she got it wet. He tried to will her into the pool.

A forbidden thrill ran down his spine like a shiver when he thought about the men of Milford Court surrounding April and jostling for position. Somehow, he was sure she'd welcome their attention. How far would she let it go? His mind went to a dark place. He saw her flushed and smiling, hanging on their every word. They'd find little excuses to touch her, growing bolder as she allowed them the freedom.

Who would she pick? The question was absurd. April wouldn't pick anyone. She wasn't a cheater. *But what if I'm not paranoid and Milford Court is some sort of wife-swapping club?*

It wouldn't matter. April doesn't want to be with anyone else.

She looked thrilled to have Chase's attention. They sat close in the pool and spoke low enough that he couldn't make out their conversation. His arm on the edge of the pool was almost around her. *Would Chase be her choice?* The guy was built. He couldn't deny that. But he seemed like such an asshole. He couldn't see her going for that. *Does that matter if it's just about sex?*

Jeremy just couldn't see her with Darius Russell. *How could I see her with anyone?* The Black man was a giant. He'd break April in half. But then, she and Cami were about the same size—except for the Latina's crazy curves. Cami had more cushion, but she handled Darius just fine. *Fuck, his cock must be huge.* He only felt a moment of guilt for allowing that stereotype into his head. *I'd never be able to please her again. Maybe she wants a man to toss her around after all these years. I'm not a wimp, but I'm not that.*

And finally, there was his boss, Tommy Siegel. They knew him the best, but that wasn't a positive. Jeremy knew April was put off by him. The man was an aging bull. There was no conceivable way she would let him touch her. *Does April have daddy issues?* He couldn't go there. She had a great relationship with her father.

But an image of Tommy mauling April popped into his head anyway. Picturing his sweet, girl-next-door wife being pounded by his boss touched

a deeper nerve than any of the others. His reaction was sharp—pleasure and pain, like the raw nerve in a tooth *and* an ache in his balls. *Why was the darkest scenario the hottest?* Jeremy knew he had to get out of the sun.

“Hey, I wouldn’t leave my wife alone with Chase for too long if I were you.”

He looked up to see Marc Goldman standing beside him. Cami’s husband was even more out of place at the gathering than he was. It was almost impossible to believe that woman was married to this man. *He’s either got a huge cock or a huge bank account—or both*, he uncharitably thought and immediately felt terrible about it.

“What? Do you mean April? She’s just trying to make a silly point. She’ll be fine.”

“Give that guy an inch... You know how the saying goes. May I?” Marc gestured to the chaise lounge beside his.

“Sure.”

“Chase is a shark. I’m sure he’s thrilled Tommy brought in some new blood.”

“I hear what you’re saying. I know his type. They’re everywhere. Shelly must have just accepted who she’s married to if she tolerates him.”

“She gets her own. I don’t think she worries too much about what he’s doing. You can’t be too possessive here. It’ll ruin you.”

Jeremy let the concerning last comment slide. “April isn’t alone with him anyway. I’m sitting right here. The backyard is full of people. What’s Chase going to do with everyone around? Besides, I think she likes the attention, and I’ll get the benefit of that later.”

Marc shook his head and laughed bitterly. “This isn’t for your benefit. I mean, you can benefit, if you want to, but it’s not about you.” He stared at Jeremy. “Shit, you don’t know, do you?”

“Know what?” Jeremy asked, although he knew.

The look on Marc’s face confirmed his worst fears. The only thing he didn’t understand was why the man wasn’t as thrilled with all of it as the other husbands—whatever *it* was. *Is it because he’s not as hot as the other guys?* Jeremy thought he held his own against the other men, except for Darius. No one held their own against that stud. None of that mattered. He and April would not be playing the kind of games couples enjoyed on Milford Court.

“No one’s filled you in on the arrangement here? You really don’t know what goes on here. I can’t believe Tommy brought you down here, moved you in, and didn’t tell you. Well, I guess I can. He is a motherfucker. Especially when he wants something.”

“Tommy didn’t sit me down and explain what you people do here, but I think I’ve figured it out. People have been dropping crazy hints since we got here, but no one has sat us down to sign forms to join your club. That is what you have, right? Some kind of kinky swingers’ club here on Milford Court.”

“It isn’t my club. I wouldn’t even call it a club. Like I said, there’s an arrangement. All the couples who live on the cul-de-sac have sort of an open-door agreement, but no one’s in charge except maybe Tommy and Marti. They are the King and Queen of the cul-de-sac, I guess. You might say the agreement is between the husbands, but it doesn’t work without the wives’ enthusiastic consent. I wouldn’t say we’re swingers. Maybe we are? I don’t really know much about that world.”

All of the vagueness was giving Jeremy a headache. Marc seemed like he was trying to help, but he was clearly worried about saying the wrong thing. The other men weren’t that shy. *Were they fucking with me, or did they think I already knew?* He finally asked, “You guys swap wives, right? Do you have these parties and pair off in different couples? That sounds like swinging to me.”

“I think swingers do different stuff? That might be preferable to this. This is more like what they call ethical non-monogamy. You could say we’re in open marriages, but it’s mostly limited to Milford Court. What happens here is all centered on the wives. It’s about giving them pleasure. That’s what the others say, anyway. But it’s just as much about the thrill of having someone else’s woman for those guys. And it’s not parties like swingers have. As I said, the cul-de-sac has an open-door policy. It’s like, whenever someone gets the urge.”

Jeremy tried to put everything into a context he could understand, but what Marc explained was so bizarre it didn’t fit with any kind of reality he could fathom. *Open-door policy? Having someone else’s woman?* People didn’t have those arrangements. That was even too far-fetched for a show like *Desperate Housewives*. Marc wanted him to believe that the husbands on Milford Court had an arrangement where they could just knock

on the door and fuck each other's wives. But only if she was in the mood. He said the wives gave *enthusiastic consent*.

The reality of it was a slap in the face when he considered it. Chase could just ring the doorbell and take April back to their bedroom while he did what? Played with the kids out by the pool? Or watched? *Does that mean I could go over there and grab Shelly?* The excitement of that didn't outweigh the gut punch of his wife being available to all the men who

lived on their street.

"Tommy should have said something before he just moved you in here, but that's Tommy. You seem like a nice guy, Jeremy. If you're not into this kind of thing, you should grab April and run."

"And you are? Into it, I mean."

Marc wouldn't meet his eyes. "It's complicated. Everything was so exciting at first that I didn't think it through. It's not the same now, but we can't leave. Cami would never go. She loves this lifestyle."

Jeremy pitied the man. He didn't like sharing his wife with the other men, but she would choose them over him. That was how it sounded. *That would never happen to us. We'd never do any of it in the first place. April doesn't want to be a shared wife.*

His heart sank when he sought his wife. She and Chase moved to the far end of the pool while he'd been talking to Marc, and she was surrounded by the other men. They'd been joined by Cami, Richelle, and Peyton. Richelle hung on Darius, who also had an arm around Cami. The trio looked like they should get a room. Tommy stood behind Peyton with his hands on her hips and looked like he was ready to bend the girl over. His eyes had been opened, and everything was sexual now. Marti watched it all from above, a serene queen surveying her subjects.

April took her hair out of the ponytail and tilted her head back under the waterfall. The water cascaded down her hair and body, soaking her. It might as well have been in slow motion. She looked like an erotic goddess, and the glee on her new friends' faces showed they approved. She basked in their attention. Jeremy's heart seized in his chest. April looked like she could slide right into being one of the shared wives of Milford Court.

